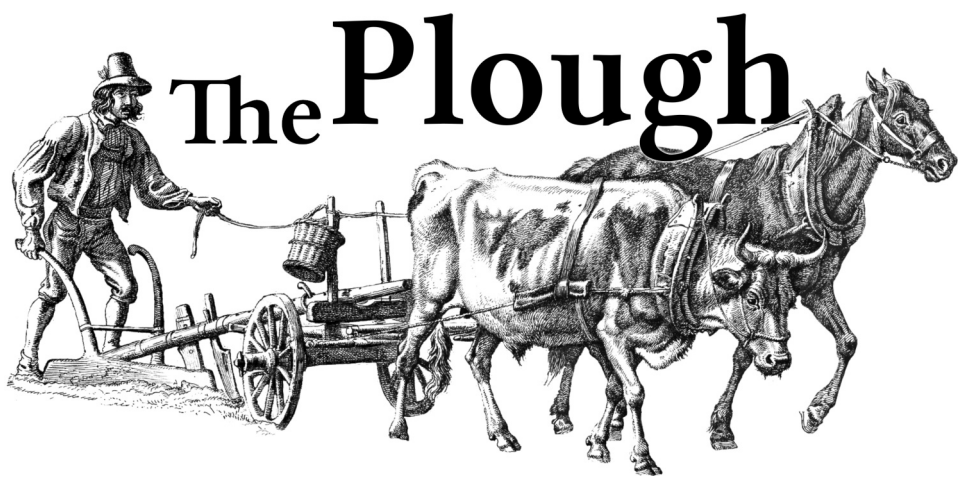




# The Plough

NEMO MITTENS MANUM SUAM AD ARATRUM, ET RESPICIENS RETRO, APTUS EST REGNO DEI  
NO MAN PUTTING HIS HAND TO THE PLOUGH, AND LOOKING BACK, IS FIT FOR THE KINGDOM OF GOD

## Featuring

### Myth of Neutrality

Arno Arcand

Is there such a thing as neutrality? Or is it a conceit; a liberal machination to wear down the Catholic spirit within men? Writing under a pseudonym, our author boldly declares against the myth of neutrality.



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### The Pacifist Extreme

Fr Charles Plater

Have modern Catholics, living in the milieu of the modern world, taken up a non-Catholic doctrine of the inadmissibility of war? Fr Charles Plater SJ elucidates this topic for us.



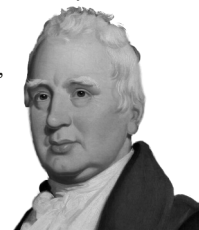
pg. 4

## Issue June 2026

### On the "Sisterhood"

Sir William Cobbett

Cobbett speaks as plainly as ever on one of the modern Catholic's taboo subjects: The sadness of a man who is ruled by the committee, or as he describes it, the sisterhood.



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# I am a Bishop!

Cardinal Pie

For the next few months, episcopal consecrations will be at the forefront of many Catholics' minds. Cardinal Pie gives a rousing sermon on the grave responsibility of the episcopacy, given in 1849, when he was installed to the See of Poitiers, France. May every bishop be enlightened by the Holy Ghost of their grave duty to preach The Faith, entire and complete, "in season and out of season".

To the people who had left the city, who had gone out into the desert to behold John the Baptist, the divine Master addressed this question: "What did you go out to see?"

I. I will ask you the same question today, my dearest Brothers: *Quid existis videre* (Luke, VII, 24)? Why this crowd out of the house, out of the city? What spectacle has set on foot this immense multitude of all ages, of both sexes, of every condition?

Once again, what did you go out to see? Is it a man clothed in luxury and ease? *Sed quid existis videre? Hominem mollibus vestimentis indutum?* No; for those who are dressed like this are found in the houses of kings (Luke, VII, 25). But the houses of kings are deserted at this hour. The word of the prophet has been fulfilled before our eyes: I will ravage, says the Lord, the winter palace and the summer palace; the houses of ivory will be plundered (Amos, III, 15). For some time, all those who had been brought up in delight have walked in harsh paths (Baruch, IV, 25); and may God grant that this is not just the beginning of sorrows (Mark, XIII, 8).

As for us, your eyes will surely not have created any illusion about these few gold and silk threads that custom has attached to our sacred ornaments, and which have nothing in common with the vain preparations of a profane finery. Moreover, courtiers are recognizable by the fact that the softness of their language agrees with that of their clothes; and the accent of our voice may have already revealed to you

that we are not of this race, and that we have not been formed in this school: *Ecce qui in veste pretiosa sunt et deliciis, in domibus regum sunt.*

But again, what did you go out to see? Is it a reed shaken by the wind: *arundinem vento agitatam?* Do you notice, my Brothers, in the question posed by the Savior, this singular alternative, or rather, this singular juxtaposition: a courtier or a reed? Is there not, in effect, more than one point of resemblance between the two? Is it not in both the same suppleness, the same inconsistency, with the same inanity?

The incomparable doctor whose disciple I am henceforth for all my life, and whose echo I should become today in this chair, Saint Hilary, develops this text thus: "The reed," he says, "has elegance, it balances its stem with grace, but it contains nothing solid; its bark is shiny, polished, pleasant, but the interior is null: *exterior placens, et nullus interior.* Thus the man of the century. He has the brilliant varnish of worldly education, but he is hollow and empty of the fruit of truth; to the specious beauty of the outside corresponds the perfect nullity of the inside; he is without firmness and without consistency; his mobility bends compliantly to all the demands of favor, it obeys without resistance all the winds of opinion; he contains in him no marrow of the spirit or of the will." Tell me, is that what you went to look for? A man empty of the knowledge of God and floating at the whim of all the impure breaths: *Numquid existis videre hominem cognitione Dei vacuum, et ad immundorum spirituum flatum vagantem?*

No, my Brothers; in coming to meet the one who is sent to you, your legitimate expectation has counted on something else. In the order of religion, the word of Jesus Christ is still true: "You went out to see a prophet, and more than a prophet: *Sed quid existis videre? Prophetam? Utique dico vobis, et plus quam prophetam*" (Luke, VII, 26). That is what was resounding just now in your streets, that is what I read inscribed on one of your triumphal arches. "And you, lately still a simple child of Israel, you will be called the prophet of the Most High, for you will walk before the face of the Lord to prepare His ways: *Et tu, puer, propheta altissimi vocaberis; praeibis enim ante faciem Domini parare vias ejus*" (Luke, I, 76).

II. But then "Who are you then?" you say to me as to John: "Who are you, so that we may give an account to those who will question us on our return to our homes: *Dixerunt ei: Quis es? ut responsum demus his qui miserunt nos?*" (John, I, 22)

My Brothers, it is again Saint Hilary who will give me my answer. "*Episcopus ego sum: I am a bishop.*" This word contains everything, this word says everything.

*I am a bishop:* I will therefore be a father, I will be a shepherd; I will love you as the father loves his children; I will guide you and nourish you as the shepherd leads and nourishes his sheep. It is my duty, it will also be my happiness to fulfill this double mission towards you. Your filial affection, your pious docility will make it easy for me. It is recommended to the shepherd to "look at the face of his flock: *Agnosce vultum pecoris tui et greges tuos considera*" (Prov, XXVII, 23). What I have read today on your faces has revealed your souls to me. What hearts those that I have seen shine on your foreheads and in your smiles! I can say to you as Paul to the Galatians: Yes, despite my obscurity, "you have not despised and rejected me, but you have received me as an angel of God, as Christ Jesus" (Galat, IV, 14).

It is true, I took care to arrive before you under the auspices of the Immaculate Virgin. In celebrating the son she sends you, you also wanted to celebrate the Mother. That is why your entire city was today only one church: the streets, the squares, the markets, the very air were as if sanctified. Under the impression of these pumps so beautiful and so gentle, it seems to me that I feel within me from this day forward what the Holy Scripture calls the bowels of paternal and pastoral affection, and that I will have no effort to make to cherish you and give you all sorts of evidence of it.

But the bishop is also something other than a father and a pastor. The mea

## Sermon of Cardinal Pie On Occasion of His Installation as Bishop of Poitiers

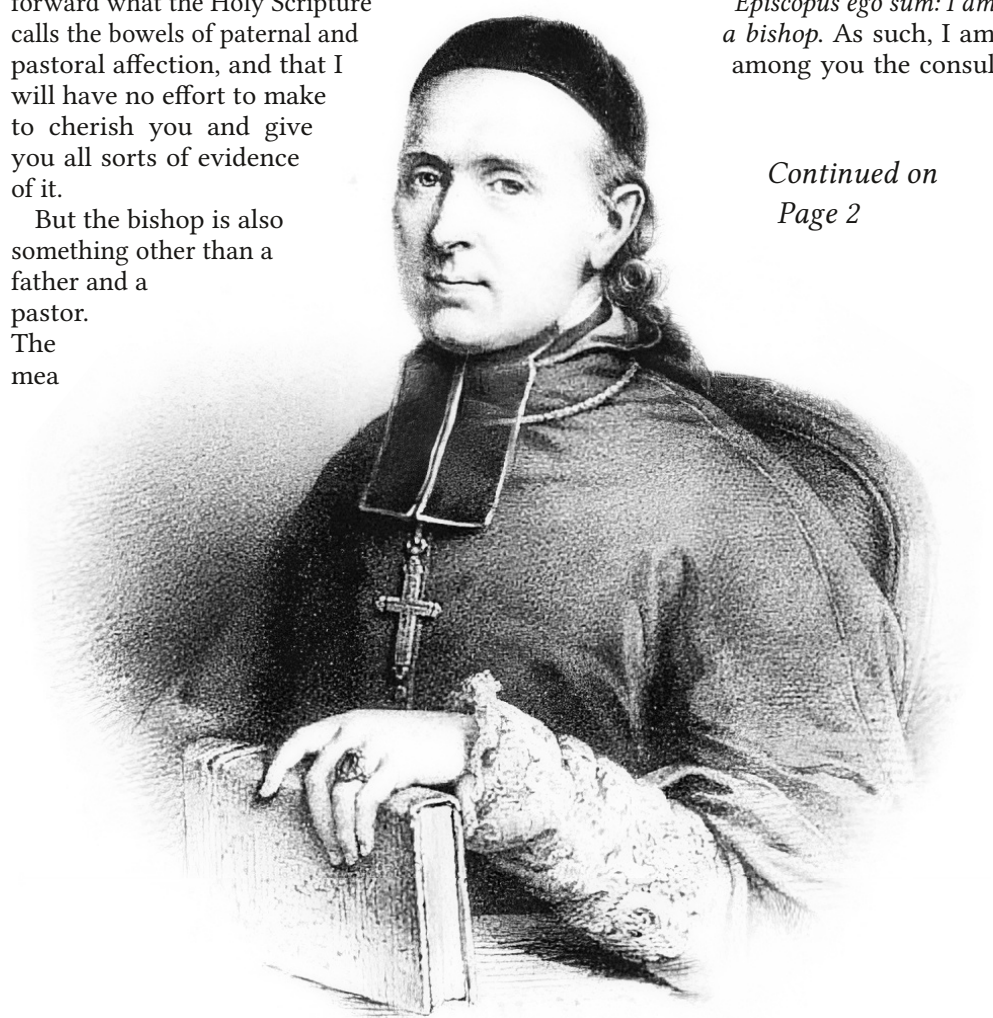
ning of his name indicates it. He is primarily "an overseer." From the observation post on which he is placed, he must observe, he must consider, and, if necessary, sound the alarm. Watchman of truth, defender of God's rights, guardian of souls: these are the sacred titles for the bishop, which carry with them inflexible obligations, unavoidable responsibilities.

*Episcopus ego sum: I am a bishop.* If, therefore, you expect me to be a man of peace, a man of conciliation, condescension, and charity, you presume nothing but the truth. With God's grace, I will be such among you. But my duties will not be limited to that, and circumstances may impose others on me that you would be less prepared to understand.

*Episcopus ego sum: I am a bishop.* As such, I am among you the consul

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*"I am a bishop:* I will therefore be a father, I will be a shepherd; I will love you as the father loves his children; I will guide you and nourish you as the shepherd leads and nourishes his sheep."



Cardinal Pie (1815–1880) in his younger years. He was beloved of Saint Pius X.





# I am a Bishop! Cont.

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of divine majesty, the ambassador and chargé d'affaires of God. If the name of the King my Master is outraged, if the flag of His Son Jesus is not respected, if the rights of His Church and His priesthood are ignored, if the integrity of His doctrine is threatened: *I am a bishop*, therefore I will speak, I will raise my voice, I will hold high and firm the standard of truth, the standard of true freedom, which is none other than the standard of faith, the standard of my God. The faint-hearted may be astonished by this, and minds of a certain caliber may even be scandalized. That is why I wanted to express myself freely from this day forward, because you cannot at this time suspect the abundance of charity that overflows from my soul.

III. Peace: yes, without a doubt, it is the ardent desire of my heart, it is the need of my nature, it is the marked inclination of my character. But the Holy Spirit has taught me that the love of truth must come before any other love, even before the love of peace: *Veritatem tantum et pacem diligit* (Zach., VIII, 19). One of the prayers that was uttered over my head on the day of my episcopal consecration was this: "*that he may love the truth, and that he may never abandon it, neither under the rule of fear,*

*nor under the rule of flattery: veritatem diligat, neque eam unquam deserat, aut laudibus aut timore superatus.*" And the experience that the world has just had should have taught you all, my Brothers, how fruitful error is in calamities of all kinds. Therefore, have confidence in our ministry, and be resolved to respect our words and our actions, even when you happen not to understand them. Let us safeguard, in their causes and in their principles, the effects and consequences to which you attach so much importance; let us work for you sometimes despite yourselves; and remember that, from the mountaintops, the shepherd sees higher and farther than the sheep softly stretched out in the plain.

No, I will exclaim with the prophet, no, "for Zion's sake I will not keep silent, and for Jerusalem's sake I will not remain quiet: *propter Sion non tacebo, et propter Jerusalem non quiescam*" (Isa., LXII, 1), until the Savior Jesus, rejected by the insolence of the men of our time, rises again over the world to enlighten it with His rays and save it by this salutary brightness. What your great doctor said here to your fathers, the spectacle of contemporary things has sufficiently confirmed it: "there is nothing so calamitous for the world as not having received Jesus Christ: *Et quid mundo tam periculosum quam non*

*recepisse Christum?*"

Also, the least Christian minds presently agree to encourage the independence of our ministry, the boldness of our speech. In these days of confusion and disorder, if the pulpits are silent, who then will speak? If the pulpits of truth are silent, who then will revive the rights of truth? Let it suffice you to know that our zeal will be invariably guided by charity, and that if we are ever compelled to make war, it will always be for the purpose of making peace, the only one worthy of the name, which is *peace in truth: pacem in veritate*.

This peace, my beloved Brothers, I wish you all today with all the effusion of the tenderness of my soul; to my brothers in the priesthood, and to those elite souls who have devoted themselves to the practice of evangelical perfection; to men constituted in dignity, and to all those who are placed under their authority; to the great and the small, to the rich and to the poor; to the old men and the young men; to the husbands and the wives; to the fathers and the children; to the just and to the sinners; to the faithful disciples of the Church, and to our separated brethren who have had the misfortune of being born outside her maternal bosom; in a word, to all those whom the grace of God and of the Apostolic See has entrusted to my care: May the blessing of

"In these days of confusion and disorder, if the prophets are silent, who then will speak? If the pulpits of truth are silent, who then will revive the rights of truth?"

the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit descend upon you, and may it remain there forever. Amen.



The crozier: the episcopal symbol of the shepherd and keeper of the flock.

## Myth of Neutrality A Political Integralist Doctrine

Arno Arcand

Arno Arcand, pseudonym, is a contemporary contributor and friend of The Plough. He writes for The Daily Fight, a publication dedicated to Catholic reactionary topics with a political theme. In this article, our author gives several concrete recommendations that will challenge our readers to go beyond in every sphere of their life.

There is a lie that has conquered the world over so completely that its no longer recognized as a lie. It is the *Myth of Neutrality*.

We are told that it is possible, virtuous even, to remain *neutral* on matters of truth and falsehood, right and wrong, the sacred and the profane. We are told that neutrality is part of the enlightened mind, one who is wise, mature, and sophisticated. To hold to firm convictions is painted as intolerance. To refuse to compromise with error is condemned as rigidity.

This is one of the greatest deceptions—if not *the* greatest deception—of the modern age, and it is the very mechanism by which the sophists of the world have triumphed over the masses.

There is no such thing as neutrality. There has never been. The myth of neutrality is merely the weapon by which the dominant ideology, the liberal order, its satanic offspring, silences opposition without appearing to oppress.

This principle deserves clear articulation: there is no middle ground between transcendent and the temporal. Every act, every choice, every moment of our lives either serves what is greater than ourselves, or it does not, and anything that does not, any moment consumed purely by self-in-

terest, any choice made for convenience alone, falls short of what we are called to be.

This is not extremism. This is simply realism about the nature of existence.

### The Pernicious Doctrine of Neutrality

The modern liberal state depends entirely upon the fiction that neutrality is possible. It tells us: *We take no position on ultimate questions. We are merely the neutral arbiter of competing interests. Religion is private. Morality is subjective. The state exists only to facilitate the freedom of individual choice.*

What a sick joke! Furthermore, the lie exists merely to serve a specific purpose: it disarms the opposition from fighting for what is rightfully theirs.

In actuality, the liberal state does enforce its very own form of metaphysics, one that denies the objective order of things, that treats man as a rights-bearing atom rather than as a member of organic communities, that reduces all questions to matters of preference and utility. It is not neutral. It is aggressively hostile to any worldview that contradicts its own.

By claiming neutrality, it prevents those who see through this deception from organizing a genuine response. We are told: *You are free to believe what you wish, but do not impose your beliefs on others.* This is the trap. For, while we are told not to impose, the liberal order does so constantly, relentlessly *imposing* its own vision through law, through education, through the entire apparatus of culture and ultimately, through the use of force.

The schools teach your children that there are no objective truths about human

sexuality, about the family, about the purpose of life, and this is not seen as imposition, but as enlightenment. The law forbids discrimination based on ideologies that contradict the natural law, and this is seen as neutrality. The media presents dissolution as progress, and this is called balance.

Meanwhile, we are told that we are the impostors if we dare to suggest that there is an objective moral order, that society should be structured according to truth, that our children should be educated in virtue rather than in the latest progressive degeneracy.

This is the mechanism of the triumph of the world over the soul, and it works precisely because it disguises itself as neutrality.

### The Metaphysical Reality: Everything Must Be Oriented Toward the Good

Nonetheless, let us speak plainly. There is no neutrality in human experience, because human experience itself is fundamentally *oriented*. We are creatures with a nature, with an end, with a purpose. Every act either moves us toward that end or away from it. There is no third category.

This is not a claim about opinion. This is metaphysics. This is the structure of reality itself.

A man who watches pornography while telling himself he is "neutral" on sexual ethics is deceiving himself. He has made a choice. That choice degrades his soul, disorders his appetites, and renders him less capable of the virtue he is called to. It does not matter that he tells himself it is "private" or that he harms no one; the harm is to his own being, to his capacity for love, to his fitness for the good life, and this furthermore supports a system that actively seeks his demise.

A parent who allows their child to be educated in schools that systematically undermine the faith while claiming that their child is receiving a "neutral educa-

"We are told: *You are free to believe what you wish, but do not impose your beliefs on others.* This is the trap."

tion" is not balanced: they are permitting the corruption of their child's soul. There is no neutrality here. There is only complicity.

A businessman who profits from the machinery of vice, from entertainment that degrades, from technologies that addict, from arrangements that exploit, who tells himself he is merely "operating in the market," has not found some middle way. He has chosen the world over his soul. Moreover, he has become an active agent in the triumphing of the world over civilization itself. Each transaction is a small cooperation with the destruction of what remains of Western moral order. Each quarter of profit is built upon the degradation of souls he will never know. He may tell himself that he is not responsible for how others use what he sells, yet he designs it precisely to addict, to corrupt, to profit from weakness. He is not innocent of market forces, he is complicit in them, deliberately so. The culture of dissolution did not happen by accident. It was built, systematically, by men who understood exactly what they were doing and chose profit over the common good. His hands are not clean because the market is amoral. His hands are dirty precisely because the market is amoral, and he chose to operate within it anyway, knowing what it would cost.

Everything in your life is oriented either toward God and the genuine good, or toward the world and its corruptions. This is not a matter of opinion. It is a matter of truth.

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# Myth of Neutrality Cont.

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Anything that falls short of being oriented toward the glory of God, toward the perfection of the virtues, toward the building of the Kingdom, falls short. Period. There is no “it’s not so bad.” There is no “everyone else is doing it.” There is only: Does this glorify God, or does it not?

### The Integralist Response: A Doctrine for Living

If we are to triumph over the world, we must cease this fantasy of neutrality and begin to live according to an *integral* vision, one in which every dimension of our lives is consciously oriented towards the true, the beautiful and the good.

This is not a call to withdraw from the world. It is a call to *conquer* it, to refuse to accept the world’s terms, to live according to our own principles, to make our choices serve something higher than comfort or acceptance.

What does this look like in practice?

### On Politics and Public Life

We must cease pretending that there exists some neutral political philosophy compatible with Catholic truth. There isn’t. Liberalism, the entire apparatus of modern political thought that claims to be neutral on ultimate questions, is fundamentally in-

compatible with the Christian vision of the common good.

This does not mean we must advocate for a theocracy in the crude sense. It means we must advocate for a *political order oriented toward the good*: one that recognizes objective truth, that structures law according to natural law, that defends the family, that protects the vulnerable from predation, that subordinates economic activity to moral purpose.

We must vote, organize, and agitate *always* with this principle in mind: Does this policy serve the genuine common good and the moral order? Or does it serve the appetites of the powerful and the confusions of the age?

We must cease splitting our votes between candidates who promise us “neutrality” on fundamental moral questions. We must cease pretending that we can support politicians who defend the slaughter of the unborn, the dissolution of the family, the persecution of conscience, merely because they offer us economic benefits or cultural victories on minor points.

We must support integralist politics, that unapologetically places the moral and spiritual order at the center, that seeks to Christianize the social order rather than merely to “manage” it.

### On Education and the Formation of the Young

Most assuredly, your child is not being educated in a neutral environment. The schools are catechizing them in a comprehensive worldview that is hostile to Christian truth.

You must take responsibility for your child’s formation. This may mean Catholic schools, if they remain truly Catholic. It may mean homeschooling. It may mean supplement, but it cannot mean abdication.

Every book your child reads, every subject they study, must be evaluated: Does this serve their formation in virtue? Does this draw them toward God? Or does it corrupt their understanding of reality?

There is no such thing as “neutral” literature or “neutral” history. Everything teaches. Everything forms. You must be intentional about ensuring that your child is being formed according to truth, not according to the lies of the age.

### On Work and Economic Life

Your work is not merely a means of acquiring money. It is an expression of your vocation, your place in the order of creation. You must refuse to participate in economic arrangements that are fundamentally unjust, or that serve the machinery of vice.

This means: Do not work for companies that profit from the degradation of human dignity. Do not participate in the financial apparatus that depends on usury and manipulation. Do not accept employment that requires you to lie, to participate in injustice, or to advance the interests of the world against the interests of the Kingdom.

If this means earning less, accepting less prestige, living more modestly, then accept it. Your soul is worth more than the world’s rewards.

Build alternative structures where possible. Support Catholic businesses. Prefer local economies to the global machinery of exploitation. Organize your economic life according to principles of justice and virtue, not merely according to profit and efficiency.

### On Entertainment and Media Consumption

There is no neutral media. Everything

This is not a call to withdraw from the world. It is a call to *conquer* it, to refuse to accept the world’s terms, to live according to our own principles, to make our choices serve something higher than comfort or acceptance.



The 'smart-phone': a great place to start when reconsidering one's priorities.

you consume is forming you, shaping your desires, teaching you how to see the world.

You must be ruthless in your refusal to consume the products of the culture industry. Television programs designed to normalize vice. Movies that celebrate the dissolution of marriage and family. Music that glorifies depravity. Social media platforms engineered to addict and to divide.

This is not prudishness. This is self-defense. Every hour you spend consuming this material is an hour you are allowing the world to triumph over your soul. Every compromise “just this one show,” “just this one platform” is a small surrender.

Reclaim your time. Read serious books. Engage in genuine conversation. Participate in the sacramental life of the Church. Cultivate beauty in your home. Spend time in nature and in genuine community.

Your leisure time is not “neutral.” It either forms you in virtue or it deforms you in vice. Choose accordingly.

### On the Family and Sexual Ethics

The family is the basic cell of society, and it is under systematic attack. You must defend it proudly and according to truth.

Reject the ideology of contraception. Un-

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Office cubicles, not the work place as God intended!

## Extract From a Diary Young Man of Character

Bishop Tihamer Toth

From his work The Young Man of Character

The following are taken from the diary of a fifth-grade student in Budapest. One of the actors is frivolously swimming with the tide, the other has character and can say *no*.

“Yesterday I went to visit Peczkai, although I do not think I shall visit him again. Schöpfer encouraged me to go, although I have always had an aversion to Peczkai. Especially when he once said after religion class: ‘This is not for grown-ups, this is for children.’

“First I have to write about his room, as disordered as a flea market. I rang the bell. A manservant in uniform opened the door: ‘The young gentleman is studying in his room. This way, please...’ In the rooms there are many indications of wealth, they are expensively furnished with Persian rugs and large paintings. I knock on the door of the ‘young

gentleman’ but he must be studying very hard because there is no answer. I open the door quietly. Peczkai is sleeping over a magazine. Under it is a French grammar book, to be switched quickly in case Dad is approaching. This time he would have gotten into trouble...

“Before awakening the diligent student, I look around the room. On the desk, there is a soccer ball with ink poured on it, a bicycle pump, half a glove, a ruler, an eraser, various buttons, and a math book. On the other side a screwdriver, a lighter, half of a Latin dictionary (the other half is under the desk). Blotting pad, 50-60 foreign stamps, skate key, cuff links. Many books, the Hungarian novels of Mikszáth mixed with mystery stories, algebra and German books. On top of it all Peczkai is peacefully asleep. (Is he this disordered inside?)

“Suddenly he wakes up. Automatically reaches for the French grammar to switch with the magazine, but when he realizes it is not his

Dad who came in, he offers his hand: ‘Oh, it is you. Hello, please take a seat. Have some cigarettes, real Egyptian’ and pulls out a lot of cigarettes from the desk.

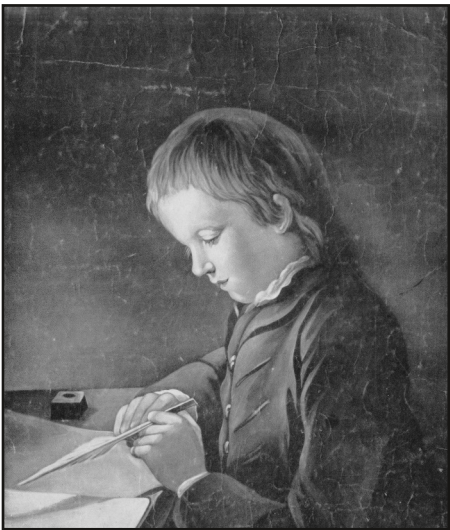
“Thank you, I do not smoke. Where did you get the cigarettes from?”

“From my Dad. You don’t smoke? Oh, you are a child who does not break the rules.”

“I started boiling inside, but answered calmly: ‘It is true I do not do what my parents forbid. I always realize that they are right. But it is also my principle not to smoke, and I stick to my principles.’ Then he started talking about his vacations at Lake Balaton and about his motorcycle. Also talked about various silly things slowly edging into indecent jokes, even though he could see that they got a very cool reception from me. Finally, when he fished out from his books photos of scantily dressed actresses, and launched into the stories of his conquests, I stood up and left.

“I was engulfed in seething anger, and it took considerable self-control to merely say in parting: ‘I believed that you invited me to a more civilized entertainment.’ After this disappointing visit I had to go out to the riverbank. Some unexplainable force drove me to the Danube, seeking fresh air and the clear night. It was a winter night, the stars sparkled in the cold sky. It was a lonely walk, my troubled soul crying to

the sky as if praying: Oh, stars, how pure you are, sparkling and spotless! And how soiled this world is, and how soiled many souls in it! I wandered around for a long time meditating on purity. This was my first visit to Peczkai, and I am quite certain that it will be my last...”



He that is faithful in that which is least, is faithful also in that which is greater.



# Myth of Neutrality Cont.

Continued from Page 3

derstand that the conjugal act is ordered toward both the unitive and procreative good, and that to deliberately frustrate this order is to disorder your marriage and your soul.

Raise your children to understand sexuality according to truth, not according to the confused and corrupting messages of the culture. Teach them that chastity is not repression but liberation, that the body is not an instrument for pleasure, but a gift ordered toward love and new life.

Do not permit your children to be groomed by the sexual ideology of the schools and the entertainment apparatus. Do not pretend that you can let them “figure it out for themselves” while the entire machinery of culture pushes them toward dissolution.

Organize your family life around the sacraments, around genuine prayer, around the transmission of faith and virtue to the next generation. This is your primary political act.

## On Intellectual Honesty and Truth-Telling

You must refuse the comfort of silence. The world rewards those who go along, who nod at the lies, who pretend not to see the obvious corruptions before them.

You must speak truth clearly and without apology. When you see injustice, name it. When you encounter lies promoted as truth, contradict them. When the powerful demand your complicity, refuse.

This will cost you. Friends will distance

themselves. Professional opportunities will evaporate. You will be slandered and misrepresented. This is the price of refusing the world’s triumphs.

Pay it. Your soul is worth more.

## The Binary Is Real

We live in an age that desperately wants to convince us that there are infinite shades of gray, that extremism is merely a matter of perspective, that the only virtue is compromise.

This is a lie designed to disarm us.

The binary that Saint Alphonsus presented is real: “*We must triumph over the world, or the world will triumph over our souls.*”

There is no middle position. There is no “both sides” in this struggle. There is only the choice between conformity to the world and fidelity to the good.

To live an integralist life is not to be rigid or inhuman. It is to be *sane*, to understand that every choice matters, that our lives are not private and neutral but are oriented toward an end, that we are called to holiness not in some remote spiritual realm but *here*, in the concrete arrangements of daily life.

It is to refuse the seduction of the myth of neutrality. It is to understand that by refusing to choose the world, we are choosing something infinitely greater.

## The Call to Courage

This will not be popular. The modern world, comfortable, progressive, convinced

of its own righteousness, will mock you for it. It will call you backward, rigid, hateful, intolerant.

Let it. These insults are merely the sound of the world’s frustration at encountering resistance to its dominion.

What we need now is not more people seeking a “balanced” middle way between truth and falsehood. What we need are *true* Catholics willing to live according to an integral vision, willing to subordinate every dimension of their lives to the pursuit of the good, willing to refuse the world’s rewards in exchange for the integrity of their souls.

We need families oriented toward the transmission of faith. We need workers who refuse to participate in injustice. We need voters who will not compromise on fundamental moral questions. We need communities built on truth rather than on the shifting sands of liberal neutrality.

This is not a call to revolution in the crude sense. It is a call to *conversion*, to a fundamental reorientation of how we live, what we value, what we are willing to sacrifice, and what we absolutely will not compromise.

The myth of neutrality has conquered because we have accepted it. We have pretended that we could be “personally opposed” to evil while permitting it to flourish. We have told ourselves that we could remain in the world without being of the world.

This ends now.

We must triumph over the world. And we do this not by grand gestures, but by

Build alternative structures where possible. Support Catholic businesses. Prefer local economies to the global machinery of exploitation. Organize your economic life according to principles of justice and virtue, not merely according to profit and efficiency.

the daily refusal to lie, the daily choice to orient ourselves toward the good, the daily decision to live according to truth rather than according to comfort.

Everything you do either glorifies God or it does not.

Choose accordingly.

You will be called retrograde, intolerant, but pay no heed to the mockery of the wicked. You must never yield! You must go into the attack whole-heartedly, not in secret but in public, not behind barred doors, but in the open, in the view of all.”

— Pope Saint Pius X

*This and more can be found at  
thedailyfightofficial.substack.com*

# The Pacifist Extreme

## The Modern Malaise

Fr Charles Plater SJ

*The notable English Jesuit Fr Charles Plater, writing on the morality of warfare, describes what he calls the ‘Pacifist Extreme’ and demonstrates how it deviates from the Catholic teaching of the legitimacy of war in certain circumstances. From his book Principles of International Morality, published in 1915.*

It is plain that the militarist doctrine that war is an end in itself, the highest expression of national life, the cause of material prosperity and moral advance, a necessary factor in human development, and so forth, is both false in theory and belied by experience. The logical outcome of militarism, when man’s intellect and will have been perverted to its service, is the apotheosis of unscrupulous strength. What are the results of the opposite extreme of pacifism, the heresy that denies to war any

lawful function at all in human affairs? Militarism masquerades as pure patriotism, whereas it is but nationalism grown rank. The false pacifism more subtly clothes itself in supernatural virtue and claims to be the quintessence of Christianity. It is all the more pernicious on that account. Historically it is connected in England with the Society of Friends, and in modern times an eminent Russian, Count Leo Tolstoy, has given the doctrine prominence in his writings. Many non-Catholic sects are tinged with it, so that in many cases the occurrence of the present war has produced a sense of divided allegiance, unintelligible to the Catholic, between duty to God and duty to the State.

The doctrine of the uniform unlawfulness of war finds no support in reason, for there is no right so fundamental as that of self-defence; and none in tradition, although attempts have been made to show that it was characteristic of early Christianity. It is based solely upon a misunderstanding of the Christian spirit produced by a misinterpretation of the Christian Scriptures. It thus illustrates the inevitable result of drawing rules for conduct entirely from written documents, which are not and cannot be self-interpreting. If there is no authority to expound and guarantee the meaning of the law, the legislator’s work is only half accomplished. God Himself is the only competent interpreter of His own laws, but, as the event proves, He does not interpret them privately for each individual, but publicly by means of the institution to which He has confided the guardianship of their written

expression. Not Tolstoy, who did not even believe in Christ’s Divinity, nor George Fox nor his followers nor any other self-accredited prophet can produce any solid reasons why men should trust in their particular exegesis of the New Testament, whereas the certain and logical issue of their doctrines in anarchy and the triumph of evil stamps them *a priori* as erroneous. It is therefore under the double guidance of reason and Catholic tradition that we arrive at the true meaning of the various passages of Holy Writ which are held to forbid warfare.

## Pacifism Refuted

In the first place reason tells us that what is essentially evil can never be positively enjoined by Almighty God as a means to any end. Yet God in His dealings with the Israelites sanctioned and approved of their fighting with their enemies, and although they might sometimes be said to be thus acting as God’s agents in overthrowing and punishing idolatry, yet this interpretation does not apply to the warfare of different sections of the Jews amongst themselves. Those, then, who say that war is always and intrinsically evil must explain how God could have countenanced the frequent employment of this wicked practice in a race which He especially wished to keep from corruption.

Turning now to the New Dispensation, we are met by the assertion that, however God may have condescended in permitting war (as He permitted divorce) to a people of low ethical development, at any rate this practice was forbidden in the law of perfection promulgated by our Lord. And texts in abundance are quoted to prove that the Christian ideal is wholly averse to the

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prosecution of even just claims by physical force or even to the warding off of unjust aggression. The Sermon on the Mount<sup>1</sup> contains the summary of Christ’s ethical teaching and therein nothing is more prominently taught than love for enemies, pardon for offences, submission to injury, the abandonment of rights whether of persons or property. A special series of benedictions is invoked on those who embrace this course of conduct. But war is essentially insistence on rights, exaction of reparation, resentment against ill-treatment. War is therefore unchristian.

To this the general reply, sufficient for the Catholic who knows that the Church is his appointed infallible guide in morals as well as in faith, is that war cannot be unchristian because, if it were, the Church would have grievously and permanently erred in a capital point of morality. This would mean, in other words, that after all there is no Church, that Christ’s promises



"Peace, peace: and there was no peace".

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# The Pacifist Extreme Cont.

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have failed, that He is not Divine nor trustworthy, and that therefore we must fall back for knowledge of the true character of war on the gropings of the unaided conscience. Consequently, a consistent Catholic must hold that the Church's interpretation of the Christian spirit is the true one, and for this interpretation he turns both to her practice and her teaching. Both are set forth in detail in other parts of this Primer, especially, as regards the past, but here attention may be called to the Crusades, officially preached and encouraged, which, in original aim at least, were wars in the strict sense, and to the fact that she has canonized, i.e. declared heroic in virtue, men and even women whose lives were largely occupied in warfare. The example in recent years of the beatification of Joan of Arc is much to the purpose.

So much for *a priori* considerations. The solution to the seeming contradiction between Our Lord's injunctions (repeated as they are in several cases by the Apostles) and Christian practice is to be sought partly in the fact that His teaching primarily regarded the individual, and only indirectly the organized community, partly in the fact that it pointed not merely to the necessary avoidance of evil, but to the voluntary aspirations towards a higher good. These two distinctions—between the duties

of the individual and of the State, and between what is more and less perfect—enable us to reconcile what might otherwise seem impracticable paradoxes. Although the same principles of morality bind both State and individual these two entities are not called to the same perfection nor have they the same destiny. Consequently, they stand in different relations towards the rights they actually possess, and the duties severally incumbent on them. The individual, having a destiny beyond this earth, may be called upon, as the martyrs were, to abandon even the right to existence in view of eternal bliss. And in the same way and for the same object he may forego many lesser temporal rights, the right to marry, to hold property, to defend himself or his goods, to control his own career, and so forth, always provided the rights of those dependent on him or otherwise connected with him are not infringed thereby. This is actually done with the sanction and approval of the Church, by those who enter Religious Orders. But no one is bound to aim at the highest. It is left to our choice—"If thou wilt be perfect."<sup>2</sup>

On the other hand, the State, having no future life to look to, must secure its own well-being here; existing, moreover, not for its own sake but for the sake of its members, it cannot arbitrarily lay aside its trust; it is bound to labour for the interests of

those members and to insist upon their rights being respected. There is no room in the scheme of things for a martyr-nation yielding to violence without any attempt at self-defence.<sup>3</sup> It would be wrong, therefore, for a State to condone grave injuries affecting its subjects or its territory; it cannot lawfully turn the other cheek to the unjust aggressor; its duty is to secure the rights of the community which have been entrusted to its keeping, by every means in its power consistent with justice.

Consequently the Quakers, the Tolstoyans and those infected with the errors of extreme pacifism are, as a matter of fact, preaching a doctrine which would certainly produce anarchy in this fallen world and which, if pursued to its logical consequences,<sup>4</sup> would disintegrate human society. For if a man or a commonwealth may not resist a foreign aggressor, they may not resist a domestic assailant. And if it is unlawful to defend oneself it is unlawful to defend others. And so criminals, collective or individual, would have a free hand, impunity would only give rise to more lawlessness, and although such anarchists would not succeed in making the world happier, even for themselves, they would not find this out till they had destroyed civilization.

## Conclusion

It must now be plain that the doctrine of the Catholic Church on war, rejecting alike the extremes of Militarism and Pacifism, is the only one which can stand the test of reason, revelation and experience. Pending the perfect establishment of God's Kingdom on earth, that is, the universal acceptance of God's Justice as the rule for all international, as well as national, dealings (an ideal which may never be wholly realized), there must occur from time to time instances of unjust and obstinate invasions of genuine rights. Pending the institution of an international tribunal on a stronger basis than that of The Hague, whose awards shall be backed by the combined forces of the civilized powers, there is no guaranteed peaceful way to settle such international disputes as may occur, in which each of the contending parties may be so convinced of the justice of its claims that it refuses to give way. In the one case and the other, things being what they are, war will tend always to recur. Evil as it is in many of its aspects and a deplorable necessity at its best, it remains the final means of preventing earth from be-

"There is no room in the scheme of things for a martyr-nation yielding to violence without any attempt at self-defence."

coming a pandemonium and humanity from lapsing into the brute.

Almighty God does not want war; on the contrary He has set up on earth a means of perpetuating with clearness, certainty and force amongst the changing generations, the principles of Christianity, the perfect observance of which would render war impossible and unthinkable. But He permits this terrible scourge, as He permits other consequences of sin and of the rejection of revealed truth, to bring home to His erring children the folly of abandoning His plans and disobeying Him. Men have the power, denied to brutes, of living by reason and law; if they choose to live by passion and instinct they cannot wonder that they fall into brute conditions. International relations have to be lifted into the region of reason and justice if civilization is to be preserved. How they have fallen away from the Christian ideal.

*Isn't it a delightful curiosity to ponder upon the coincidence that at the time that men have the least testosterone ever measured, man is the most confused about the justice of war in certain circumstances?*

1. Taken together and apart from their circumstances these utterances of Our Lord certainly point to a spirit which possessed in its fullness would make war impossible. "But I say to you not to resist evil: but if one strike thee on thy right cheek turn to him also the other"; "Love your enemies, do good to them that hate you"; "Blessed are the meek". And, certainly, if all acted in accord with these counsels there would be no war. His example in His Passion, especially His express repudiation of physical force, points in the same direction. But Our Lord's doctrine as to the conduct of Christian States is not meant to be inferred from isolated sayings, but from the aim of His whole life as interpreted by His Spirit in the Church.

2. We are not concerned here with vindicating for the individual the freedom, which God has allowed him, to distinguish between counsels and commands, and to choose, if he wishes, the lower good rather than the higher within the limits of God's law. We need only note that a freedom given to the individual who has only himself to look to does not necessarily extend to the State, the guardian of so many interests.

3. The great merit of Belgium is that having done enough for honour and more than enough for justice, she still pursues resistance to iniquity. She is a martyr-nation in another sense.

4. Of course it is not so pursued: and though we regard this doctrine of the Society of Friends as indefensible, we readily render our tribute of admiration for their staunch adhesion to convictions which are unpopular, and for their untiring and generous spirit of charity.



War for peace is Christian. Let us not cower away from this responsibility.

## June 3: St Clotilda

### Lives of the Saints

Alban Butler

From the Benziger Brothers edition of *Lives of the Saints*, 1910.

St. Clotilda was daughter of Chilperic, younger brother to Gondebald, the tyrannical King of Burgundy, who put him and his wife, and his other brothers, except one, to death, in order to usurp their dominions. Clotilda was brought up in her uncle's court, and, by a singular providence, was instructed in the Catholic religion, though she was educated in the midst of Arians. Her wit, beauty, meekness, modesty, and piety made her the adoration of all the neighboring kingdoms, and Clovis, surnamed

the Great, the victorious king of the Franks, demanded and obtained her in marriage. She honored her royal husband, studied to sweeten his warlike temper by Christian meekness, conformed herself to his humor in things that were indifferent, and, the better to gain his affections, made those things the subject of her discourse and praises in which she knew him to take the greatest delight. When she saw herself mistress of his heart she did not defer the great work of endeavoring to win him to God, but the fear of giving offense to his people made him delay his conversion. His miraculous victory over the Alemanni, and his entire conversion in 496, were at length the fruit of our Saint's prayers. Clotilda, having gained to God this great monarch, never ceased to excite him to glorious actions for the divine honor; among other religious foundations, he built in Paris, at

her request, about the year 511, the great church of Sts. Peter and Paul, now called St. Genevieve's. This great prince died on the 27th of November, in the year 511, at the age of forty-five, having reigned thirty years. His eldest son, Theodoric, reigned at Rheims over the eastern parts of France, Clodomir reigned at Orleans, Childebert at Paris, and Clotaire at Soissons. This division produced wars and mutual jealousies, till in 560 the whole monarchy was reunited under Clotaire, the youngest of these brothers. The dissension in her family contributed more perfectly to wean Clotilda's heart from the world. She spent the remaining part of her life in exercises of prayer, almsdeeds, watching, fasting, and penance, seeming totally to forget that she had been queen or that her sons sat on the throne. Eternity filled her heart and employed all her thoughts. She foretold her death thirty days before it happened. On the thirtieth day of her illness, she received the sacraments, made a public confession of her faith, and departed to the Lord on the 3rd of June, in 545.

*Reflection* St. Peter defines the mission of the Christian woman: to win the heart of those who believe not the word.



St Clotilda, ora pro nobis!





# Catholics and The Republic

## Acción Española On Legitimacy

Fr Gumersindo de Escalante OFM

*This article tackles the question of whether or not an illegitimate government needs to be obeyed. In Spain and France in the early 20th century, this was a particularly important question, as polity of both these states were now both governed in the form of judeo-masonic republics, an intolerable situation for any Catholic. This discussion is set in the form of a response to a contemporaneous article written in France and published in La Croix a Catholic reactionary newspaper of the day. Our author accuses the author of the La Croix article of being soft on these republics, and who argues that over time these republics have come to be legitimate and therefore it is necessary to obey them. In response, we see zeal from Fr Escalante for the Catholic cause, who reminds us that for no matter how long an injustice is tolerated, the injustice doesn't become just by the passage of time.*

We have read an article published in *La Croix*, a Catholic newspaper in Paris, dedicated to commenting on the Spanish situation and, more particularly, the situation of Spanish Catholics in the face of the republican regime established in Spain. The author, León Merklen, limits himself almost exclusively to commenting on the famous article in *El Debate*, "Catholics and the Republic," which stirred such lively discussions in the Spanish press.

We would not insist again on such an unfortunate matter if the author of *La Croix*, in his article, had limited himself to treating the question in its political aspect; but seeing him invade the terrain of dogma and morality with manifest incompetence, and considering the confusion that his words, reproduced in a Madrid daily newspaper of wide circulation, could produce in the intelligences of certain Catholics who are not very strong in these matters, we have not resisted the desire to dedicate a few brief comments to said article.

In the first place, we do not know who has granted Mr. Merklen authority to define matters of faith and morality, passing off his particular assessments, full of inaccuracies, as the current doctrine of the Church, as we shall see immediately.

"It is embarrassing," says the author, "to recall the simple principles that guide the Catholic Church in its relations with the various kinds of regimes that may prevail in a country."

We are also embarrassed to see how such simple principles are so pitifully interpreted and muddled by Mr. Merklen in his article, mixing totally distinct questions and making completely gratuitous assertions.

For example, the author says: "Whatever the regime established in a country, from the moment that this regime is born of a *de facto* possession such that it could only be modified by a violent revolution, which would cause serious damage to the common good of the nation, from the moment that said regime seeks in principle to achieve the common good, and consequently, does not pride itself on attending, for example, to the interests of a single social class and on attacking the religious rights of citizens or the Church; the Church is practically with that regime and asks the faithful to loyally recognize its authority."

Here there is enormous confusion. According to the current doctrine of all Catholic theologians, mere *de facto* possession does not give legitimacy to a government or a regime. A regime that is born of injustice or violence, even if it has managed to consolidate itself perfectly, so that it is not possible to overthrow it except by a violent revolution, even if it is in peaceful possession of power, will never be legitimate. It does not matter that it uses power moderately and seeks the common good; that power will always be usurped and, consequently, illegitimate; in the same way that a thief does not legitimize his theft nor make what was stolen his own by the simple fact of his peaceful possession

and even if he uses the stolen money for good purposes.

An illegitimate authority by its origin is not true authority, it is usurping, it is tyrannical, by the mere fact of exercising power without any title to do so; the fact that a usurpation is a *fait accompli* does not give any legitimacy to the usurpation. Does the author of *La Croix* realize the enormity he incurs by making the Church an accomplice to the absurd theory of *faits accomplis*? Mr. Merklen would be hard-pressed to justify with such a doctrine the conduct of his holy compatriot Joan of Arc in her warlike adventures against the English, peaceful possessors of extensive regions of France for many years.

What the author says about the Church being practically with such regimes needs explanation. The Church can never approve a usurpation, even if it is consummated and consolidated. The author should not confuse the Vicar of Jesus Christ with the temporal sovereign of the Vatican City. The Pope sometimes recognizes these *de facto* governments, illegitimate in their origin, but only as *de facto* governments, without his recognition signifying approval or much less legitimizing their authority, exactly as other powers do. The Pope, as the representative of the Church and genuine defender of the spiritual rights of all his faithful in all countries of the world, in order to effectively defend those rights, sometimes decides to agree and deal with the *de facto* governments existing in those countries, without this signifying recognition of their legitimacy. Only in this sense can what the author says about the Church being practically with those governments and regimes be admitted.

Therefore, if the Church does not recognize, nor can it recognize, such *de facto* authorities as legitimate, neither can it demand that its faithful loyally recognize them, as Mr. Merklen claims; the only thing that the Church demands in those cases is mere compliance, that is, obedience to the decrees and laws emanating from that *de facto* authority, provided that they are just in themselves, and only when disobedience can cause some damage to the common good; and that, not because

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the authority has any right to command, nor the subjects any obligation to obey, but because of the duty that every citizen has to cooperate for the good of society and avoid any damage to it, which duty requires obedience to the authorities currently existing, as long as there is no possibility of restoring the true and legitimate authority.

The author continues: "No Catholic can condemn the established regime as contrary to the teachings of philosophy and faith, because this would have as a consequence using Catholicism in favor of a political opinion, identifying the Catholic cause with that of a party."

The author seems to think his fingers are guests. No Catholic with any common sense has ever thought of identifying Catholicism with any political regime. Mr. Merklen moves with astonishing agility from the abstract to the concrete and from the concrete to the abstract. In theory, any regime, provided it is suitable for the common good, can be accepted by a Catholic; but in practice, since the regime established in a country is either legitimate or illegitimate, if, hypothetically, it is illegitimate, no Catholic can approve or accept it, just as it is not lawful to approve or accept theft.

Let's take an example. A gang of thieves steals a large sum of money, and with the stolen money, they set up a company or industrial or commercial enterprise to exploit a business. Clearly, that company or business, considered in the abstract, can be a

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# Character

## What is It?

Fr Bede Jarrett

From his work *Meditations for Layfolk*, 1915

Many people seem to worry themselves a great deal more over the things that they cannot help than over the things that they can. They are greatly agitated over the colour of their hair (for which they are not responsible), and but little over their tempers (for which they are). This want of proportion is doubtless observable in myself. Do I think more of the accidents of birth, fortune, personal appearance, than of the self that I have created? For I myself am responsible for myself. "To be born a gentleman is an accident, to die one is an achievement." Other things, then, I may not be able to help, but myself I can. As I am at this very moment, as my character is truthful or untruthful, pure or impure, patient or impatient, slow to wrath or quick-tempered, eager, enthusiastic, energetic, or lazy and dull and wasteful of time I have no

one to thank but my own self. Of course, I may blame my temperament and say I was born so; I may accuse the hereditary tendencies of my family, or excuse myself because I have been spoilt or cowed or left to my own devices, or have been deluged with too much religion or starved with too little. But despite all this, the fact remains that I myself alone am responsible for my own character; for character is an artificial thing that is not born, but made: it is the result of human effort and human guidance, of human wisdom and human folly. I am as I am now to the eye of God because I have so made or marred myself, either deliberately and of set purpose, or else by allowing myself to drift along, and never moving hand or foot to save myself from peril.

But surely there is such a thing as temperament? Surely people really are different from birth? Surely even the physical formation of the body, physical health or the want of it, the health and desires and moods of our parents at the moment of conception, the whole stream of tendencies inherited or instilled in early childhood, the evils produced by a neglected education or an up bringing that is not Catholic, do most certainly affect my nature and make some difference to me? Have I not, on their account, some justification in excusing myself from being wholly responsible for the evils in my character? Here I must begin by

realizing that I must make a very real distinction between temperament and character. Temperament is natural, I am born with it; character is artificial, the result of my way of life. I am born with a certain definite temperament, and for this I am not responsible; and on this account, too, I may well suppose that God will make allowances for me. At any rate this temperament gives me a set off, a push, in one definite direction: for some are by nature gentle, generous, and obliging, while others as naturally are cross-tempered and easily ruffled. But this need not settle my character. Of course, if I make no effort to tame any evil tendencies of my nature, then temperament and character will coincide and my actual life will only mark more deeply and emphasize more pronouncedly the original defect with which I started. But that is my own affair, for it is possible for me to act in opposition to my temperament and to produce a character that is the reverse of my nature.

Saint Thomas, indeed, in a very brief passage, seems to suggest that the worse our natural temperament is, the better for us; nor is it at all difficult to understand his argument. If I have a bad temper by nature, let me first of all go down on my knees and thank God for it; for it is surely highly probable that if I had a good temper I should be obliging and kind, not from any supernatural motive but from sheer nature.

Supposing I was of that comfortable disposition which says "Yes" just because it finds it impossible to say "No," surely my acts would hardly ever be supernaturalized. But, on the other hand, supposing I am so cantankerous that I can be generous and helpful only at the cost of a mighty effort, then I can be certain that every obliging thing I do is done only from a high motive: it is the very contrary force which stiffens me into goodness. Just as an enemy is the necessary material out of which to fashion victory, so is an evil temperament the foundation on which a strong character is to be built up. This character is, of course, nothing else than the group of habits formed round the axis of the will; and these are achieved only by repeated acts, so that it is by deliberate and energetic actions alone that I can react against my own temperament. But, above all, I must beware of allowing myself to be careless in life, without ambition or ideal or plan; for to drift through existence is at least as dangerous as deliberate evil consciously performed: I am quick, then, by nature, or mean or thronged with impure imaginings. It does not much matter what my own trouble may be, but, instead of bemoaning it, I should set to work by deliberate and conscious reason to reform myself under the grace of God, not follow the blind impulses of nature.





# Catholics and The Republic Cont.

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perfectly legitimate thing, but it is not lawful or acceptable to establish it with stolen capital.

A few men gather one day and, by violence or deceit, overthrow the legitimate regime that existed in a country, seize power, and establish themselves as a Republic, let's say. Clearly, the Republic, as a Republic, is one of many lawful regimes that a nation can have, but since in this specific case it is based on usurpation, it cannot be approved or accepted, just as the establishment of a company or business made with stolen capital cannot be accepted or approved. A Catholic, therefore, cannot condemn any established regime in the abstract as contrary to philosophy and faith, but he can and must condemn an illegitimate regime established against the laws of justice.

"Even less can a Catholic," continues Mr. Merklen, "seek violent, illegal, and revolutionary means to destroy the existing regime, because in this way he would fail in his duty to respect legitimate authority and would sin against the law of God."

Firstly, the writer starts from the erroneous assumption that every de facto established regime is legitimate authority, which is totally false, as you can verify by reading any Catholic theology manual. Afterwards, he makes a picturesque mix of concepts, speaking of violent, illegal, and revolutionary means, as if they were synonymous words. Citizens can resist and even overthrow a usurping government by violence, provided that, in doing so, they do not cause society greater evils than those that would follow from consenting to the usurpation. Therefore, such attitudes and violent means are perfectly lawful and cannot be called illegal in any way. As for the term "revolutionary," it depends on the meaning the writer wants to give it. If by revolutionary is meant overthrowing an illegitimate regime to restore the legitimate one, it is absolutely lawful, with the appropriate reservations.

What the writer says a little later, that "one must always remain within the legal order, without coups and without rebellions that conscience condemns," is true only in the case of legitimate governments or regimes. Against a legitimate government, coups and rebellions are unlawful; but against a usurping government, who told Mr. Merklen that active resistance and

uprisings are unlawful? Let the writer read any Catholic theology or moral treatise, and he will see how it says there that society is entitled to declare war and even depose by force the usurper who has risen to power without just title. "He who violently seized authority," says Saint Thomas, "is not in reality superior, nor does he possess authority or title to demand obedience. Hence, if the subjects have the possibility of doing so, they can reject and oppose such a pseudo-superior." (*Comm. in Lib. secundum Magistri Sententiarum, Dist. 44, art. 2, quaest. 2.*) "Against a tyrant who unjustly seized power," says Soto, "and society has not consented to or validated such usurpation, any citizen has the right to kill him, for it is lawful to repel force with force, and the tyrant, as far as the title is concerned, is in perpetual war against society." (*De "Justicia et Jure", Lib. V, art. 3, quaest. 3.*) "The tyrant, as far as the title is concerned," says Suárez, "for the very reason that he possesses authority unjustly and relying only on force, always inflicts violence in deed to society; and consequently, it is in constant defensive war against the tyrant, and as long as society does not declare otherwise, it can be lawfully defended against such a tyrant by any of its subjects and even by foreign persons to it, and if there were no other way to defend itself from the tyrant, anyone can lawfully kill him, because in this case he would not act with private authority, but with the implicit authority of the society itself." (*"Defensio Fidei catholicae et apostolicae adversus anglicanae sectae errores", Lib. VI, cap. 4, pág. 720. V. Acción Española, págs. 499.461.*)

Does the writer of *La Croix* want a greater coup than the death of the tyrant? We agree with the writer that one must remain within the legal order, but let it be noted that an illegitimate regime is not a legal order, nor is it constitutional, since the constitution given by a usurping government has no binding force whatsoever, since such a government lacks the legal authority to promulgate it. We do not know, therefore, what Mr. Merklen means when he affirms "that the constitutional ground is the ground of facts." Does he mean that citizens are obliged to adhere to and submit to the existing Constitution *de facto* in a nation, whether or not it has a legal origin? Well, we have already warned above that such a Constitution lacks binding force, and, therefore, citizens could

hardly be obliged to obey and respect it; only if their disobedience caused some harm to society and while there is no possibility of restoring legitimate authority, would citizens be obliged to abide by it in what is just.

"Every society," Mr. Merklen goes on to say, "needs a government; therefore, the one that exists in fact in the nation represents in fact, despite its imperfections, and sometimes the illegality of its origin, the authority of God."

According to that, any thief who, gun in hand, enters a house and starts giving orders, represents the authority of God? Because also in every family an authority is always needed and the thief who, gun in hand, gives orders, is the authority of the moment, that would be curious!

Here is what Saint Thomas says in this regard, if Mr. Merklen considers the authority of Saint Thomas to be weighty: "Only insofar as the authority of secular powers proceeds and is from God, are Christians obliged to obey them; but they are not when the authority is not or does not come from God. Authority may not be or may not come from God for two reasons: with regard to the manner of acquiring it or with regard to the exercise thereof. In turn, with regard to the first reason, the acquisition of authority, this may not come from God for two causes: due to the unworthiness of the person or due to the manner of acquiring it, for example, if there was violence, simony or some other kind of illegality. With regard to the latter case, whoever claims to be superior prevents the acquisition of the right to command. Thus, whoever seized power by violence is not really superior, does not possess authority or title to demand obedience."

From these words of Saint Thomas it follows that the authority of an illegitimate government, that is, one that has seized command by violence or any other illicit means, is not true authority, and that it is not and does not come from God; therefore, that government can hardly represent the authority of God. And let it not be said that, given that there is only that illegitimate authority in society, it represents the authority of God for the moment. If the person or persons who exercised the legitimate authority exist, before the usurpation, it continues to reside in them and they really represent the divine authority, and if not, it resides in the society itself.

To an illegitimate government or regime, therefore, that has not received its authority from God and, for the same reason, does not represent the authority of God, we citizens are not obliged to lend loyal support, as Mr. Merklen claims; on the contrary, we would sin in conscience if we lent it, making ourselves accomplices to an injustice, unless the common good required merely external cooperation, to avoid greater evils to society.

But the most amazing thing about Mr. Merklen's article is the final consequence he draws from his disastrous argument. "The loyal acceptance, for example, of the Republic in Spain consists in recognizing the new regime as the legitimate authority of the moment and in promising it fidelity and services, not because it is a Republic, but because it is a constitutional government."

All this borders on the facetious, and we have been tempted not to even take it seriously. Does Mr. Merklen want to tell us what he means by the legitimate authority of the moment? Because we cannot quite understand it. Does he mean that the au-

"Citizens can resist and even overthrow a usurping government by violence, provided that, in doing so, they do not cause society greater evils than those that would follow from consenting to the usurpation."

thority that actually governs in a country is legitimate while it actually governs, or in other words, that that authority is provisionally legitimate? Then, as Mr. Merklen has said before that coups and uprisings against an authority of fact, legitimate for the moment, are illicit, it turns out that we have legitimate authority for in *saecula saeculorum*. What, are there still legal means left? It is supremely naive to think that a usurping government is going to grant in its constitution legal means to be overthrown. In all constitutions the regime is always considered untouchable. From which it follows that the legitimate authority of the moment becomes the legitimate authority definitively, by the sole title of the possession of fact, and with it the theory of accomplished facts is consecrated. Let Mr. Merklen bear the responsibility for such a theory, but let him not say that this is the current doctrine of the Church.

But what reaches the height of grace is the reason given by the article writer for us to submit to that legitimate authority of the moment: "because it is a constitutional government", taking, apparently, constitutional as a synonym for legitimate. Constitutional means in all countries adjusted to the Constitution; but what Constitution? The one that existed before the usurpation? Then, the usurping government is unconstitutional. The one that the usurping government has given? Since the usurping government is illegitimate, it has no authority to give constitutions, then the Constitution that it has made is waste paper. Let Mr. Merklen decipher that logogriph.

We Spaniards know very well what we have to do with respect to the Republic without any Frenchman coming to teach us. We Spanish Catholics will recognize the Republic as a simple government of fact, and thanks. Moreover, we know perfectly well how this regime was born and the degrees of legitimacy that it can allege; we also know that the Spanish people have not yet accepted the regime, because one part, the healthiest, has always been hostile, and another very numerous part has refrained from expressing an opinion. Therefore, one cannot speak of acceptance of the regime by the Spanish people, unless Mr. Merklen understands by the Spanish people that absurd conglomerate of socialists, radicals, communists, and anarchists, who have governed us during two deadly years.

When the Spanish Republic has shown us its titles of legitimacy, we will recognize it; meanwhile, it will be content with us obeying it, as much as possible, and looking to the good of the country, and even less so, from the moment that this regime does not seek the common good, attending to the interests of only one social class and fighting against the religious rights of citizens and the Church; the Constitution is a witness.

The authority that is usually attributed to Mr. Merklen precisely in these religious and political matters, we do not see anywhere.



France's monarchy was famously usurped in 1789, and was since then ruled as a republic (with some intervening royalist reprisals), while Spain was usurped nearly a century later, ultimately giving way to the First Spanish Republic in 1873. Catholics of both nations hold dearly to their former respective monarchies, with many reactionary Catholic movements revolving around legitimist figures such as Don Sixto Enrique de Borbón of Spain and Louis Alphonse de Bourbon, Duke of Anjou, France.



# On the “Sisterhood”

## Advice to Young Men

Sir William Cobbett

This perennial wisdom from William Cobbett, Englishman and defender of the poor, family life, and traditionalism, comes from his small edition *Advice to Young Men*, published in 1829. With a striking accuracy, Sir Cobbett diagnoses a condition all too prevalent today and recommends a remedy. This article begins part way through the text.

182. But though all the aforementioned considerations demand from us the kindest possible treatment of a wife, the husband is to expect dutiful deportment at her hands. He is not to be her slave; he is not to yield to her against the dictates of his own reason and judgment; it is her duty to obey all his lawful commands; and, if she have sense, she will perceive that it is a disgrace to herself to acknowledge, as a husband, a thing over which she has an absolute control. It should always be recollected that *you* are the party whose body must, if any do, lie in jail for debt, and for debts of her contracting, too, as well as of your own contracting. Over her *tongue*, too, you possess a clear right to exercise, if necessary, some control; for if she use it in an unjustifiable manner, it is against *you*, and not against her, that the law enables, and justly enables, the slandered party to proceed; which would be monstrously unjust, if the law were not founded on the *right* which the husband has to control, if necessary, the tongue of the wife, to compel her to keep it within the limits prescribed by the law. A charming, a most enchanting life, indeed, would be that of a husband, if he were bound to cohabit with and to maintain one for all the debts and all the slanders of whom he was answerable, and over whose conduct he possessed no compulsory control.

183. Of the *remedies* in the case of *really bad* wives, squanderers, drunkards, adulteresses, I shall speak further on; it being the habit of us all to put off to the last possible moment the performance of disagreeable duties. But, far short of these

vices, there are several faults in a wife that may, if not cured in time, lead to great unhappiness, great injury to the interests as well as character of her husband and children; and which faults it is, therefore, the husband's duty to correct. A wife may be chaste, sober in the full sense of the word, industrious, cleanly, frugal, and may be devoted to her husband and her children to a degree so enchanting as to make them all love her beyond the power of words to express. And yet she may, partly under the influence of her natural disposition, and partly encouraged by the great and constant homage paid to her virtues, and presuming, too, on the pain with which she knows her will would be thwarted; she may, with all her virtues, be thus led to a *bold interference in the affairs of her husband*; may attempt to dictate to him in matters quite out of her own sphere; and, in the pursuit of the gratification of her love of power and command, may wholly overlook the acts of folly or injustice which she would induce her husband to commit, and overlook, too, the contemptible thing that she is making the man whom it is her duty to honour and obey, and the abasement of whom cannot take place without some portion of degradation falling upon herself. At the time when ‘The Book’ came out, relative to the late ill-treated Queen Caroline, I was talking upon the subject, one day, with a *parson*, who had not read ‘The Book’, but who, as was the fashion with all those who were looking up to the government, condemned the Queen unheard. ‘Now,’ said I, ‘be not so shamefully unjust; but *get the book*, read it, and then give your judgment.’—‘Indeed,’ said his wife, who was sitting by, ‘but he *sha’n’t*,’ pronouncing the words *sha’n’t* with an emphasis and a voice tremendously masculine. ‘Oh!’ said I, ‘if he *sha’n’t*, that is another matter; but, if he *sha’n’t* read, if he *sha’n’t* hear the evidence, he *sha’n’t* be looked upon, by me, as a just judge; and I *sha’n’t* regard him, in future, as having any opinion of his own in anything.’ All which the husband, the poor henpecked thing, heard without a word escaping his lips.

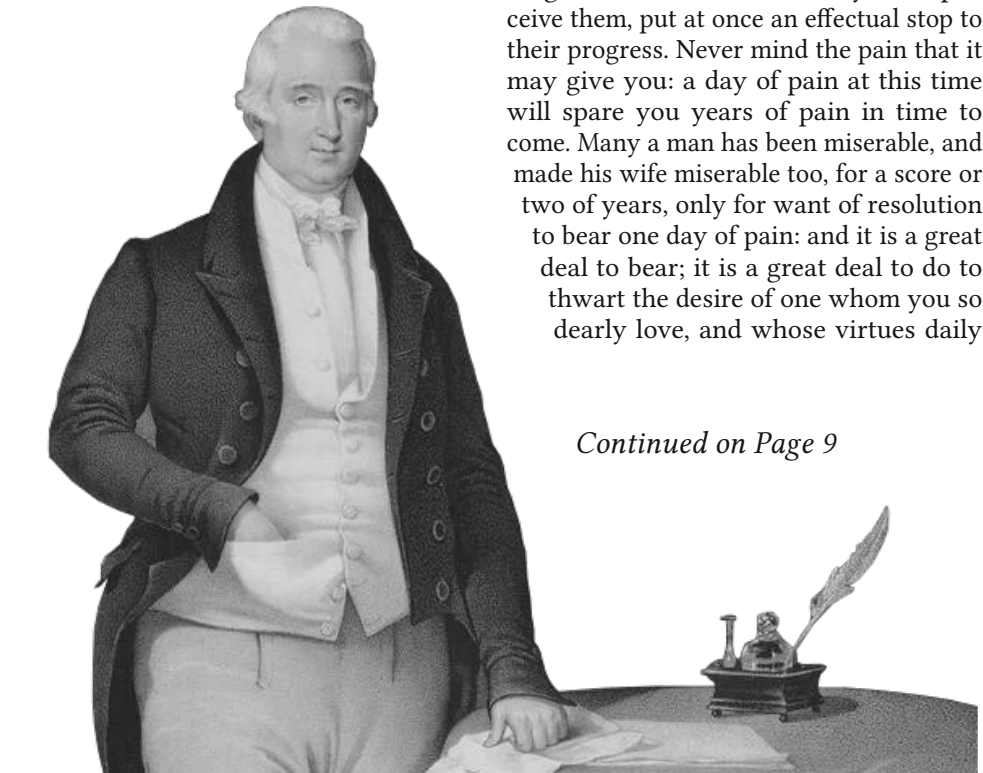
184. A husband thus under command, is the most contemptible of God's creatures. Nobody can place reliance on him for any-

thing; whether in the capacity of employer or employed, you are never sure of him. No bargain is firm, no engagement sacred, with such a man. Feeble as a reed before the boisterous she-commander, he is bold in injustice towards those whom it pleases her caprice to mark out for vengeance. In the eyes of neighbours, for *friends* such a man cannot have, in the eyes of servants, in the eyes of even the beggars at his door, such a man is a mean and despicable creature, though he may roll in wealth and possess great talents into the bargain. Such a man has, in fact, no property; he has nothing that he can rightly call *his own*; he is a beggarly dependent under his own roof; and if he have anything of the man left in him, and if there be rope or river near, the sooner he betakes him to the one or the other the better<sup>1</sup>. How many men, how many families, have I known brought to utter ruin only by the husband suffering himself to be subdued, to be cowed down, to be held in fear, of even a virtuous wife! What, then, must be the lot of him who

“A husband thus under command, is the most contemptible of God's creatures. Nobody can place reliance on him for anything; whether in the capacity of employer or employed, you are never sure of him.”

submits to a commander who, at the same time, sets all virtue at defiance!

185. Women are a *sisterhood*. They make *common cause* in behalf of the *sex*; and, indeed, this is natural enough, when we consider the vast power that the *law* gives us over them<sup>2</sup>. The law is for us, and they combine, wherever they can, to mitigate its effects. This is perfectly natural, and, to a certain extent, laudable, evincing fellow-feeling and public spirit: but when carried to the length of ‘*he sha’n’t*,’ it is despotism on the one side and slavery on the other. Watch, therefore, the incipient steps of encroachment; and they come on so slowly, so softly, that you must be sharp-sighted if you perceive them; but the moment you *do perceive them*: your love will blind for too long a time; but the moment you do perceive them, put at once an effectual stop to their progress. Never mind the pain that it may give you: a day of pain at this time will spare you years of pain in time to come. Many a man has been miserable, and made his wife miserable too, for a score or two of years, only for want of resolution to bear one day of pain: and it is a great deal to bear; it is a great deal to do to thwart the desire of one whom you so dearly love, and whose virtues daily

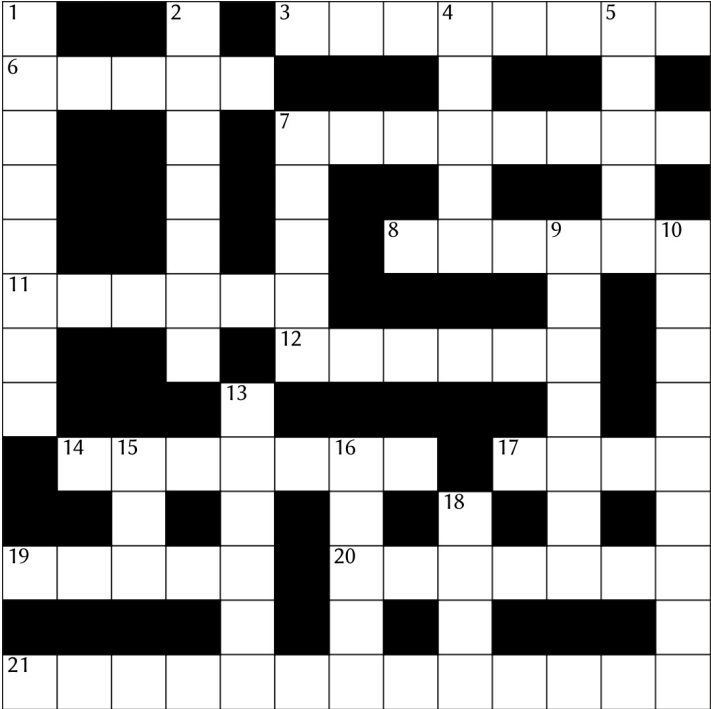


Sir William Cobbett: defender of tradition, the poor, and an out-spoken member of parliament.

Continued on Page 9

# PUZZLES FOR THE LETTERED FOLK

## CROSSWORD



### Across

- 3) Region of France, a former duchy and kingdom (8)
- 6) A common misspelling of the word angel (5)
- 7) Those rules made by man which govern the life of the 'city' of public realm (5-3)
- 8) The only English Pope (6)
- 11) Anglican prelate who converted to Catholicism in the 19th century (6)
- 12) Gardening tool (6)
- 14) One more than monism (7)
- 17) The book after the Gospel according to the St John (4)
- 19) A pamphlet or short writing making an argument (5)
- 20) Male of a particular species of poultry (7)
- 21) First word of an encyclical by Pope Pius XI meaning '40' (13)

### Down

- 1) Wine grape variety (8)
- 2) Esoteric study of chemically synthesising gold (7)
- 4) Corporate society consisting of workmen of the same trade (5)
- 5) Greek goddess whose temple was situated in Ephesus and is mentioned in the Sacred Scriptures (5)
- 7) French word for singing or song (5)
- 9) Synonym for illegal (7)
- 10) Latin expression for 'New Order' (5-4)
- 13) Province of Ireland identified with the 'red hand' (6)
- 15) Pope Leo XIII condemned an attitude originating from this country (3)
- 16) Modern state in the levant which was once under a French mandate (5)
- 18) A single unit of a skeleton (4)

## CALTROP SWEEPER

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# On the “Sisterhood” Cont.

Continued from Page 8

render her more and more dear to you. But (and this is one of the most admirable of the mother’s traits) as she herself will, while the tears stream from her eyes, force the nauseous medicine down the throat of her child, whose every cry is a dagger to her heart; as she herself has the courage to do this for the sake of her child, why should you flinch from the performance of a still more important and more sacred duty towards herself, as well as towards you and your children?

186. Am I recommending *tyranny*? Am I recommending *disregard* of the wife’s opinions and wishes? Am I recommending a *reserve* towards her that would seem to say that she was not trust-worthy, or not a party interested in her husband’s affairs? By no means: on the contrary, though I would keep anything disagreeable from her, I should not enjoy the prospect of good without making her a participator. But reason says, and God has said, that it is the duty of wives to be obedient to their husbands; and the very nature of things prescribes that there must be a *head* of every house, and an *undivided* authority. And then it is so clearly *just* that the authority should rest with him on whose head rests the whole responsibility, that a woman, when patiently reasoned with on the subject, must be a virago in her very nature not to submit with docility to the terms of her marriage vow.

187. There are, in almost every considerable neighbourhood, a little squadron of she-commanders, generally the youngish wives of old or weak-minded men, and generally without children. These are the

tutoresses of the young wives of the vicinage; they, in virtue of their experience, not only school the wives, but scold the husbands; they teach the former how to encroach and the latter how to yield: so that if you suffer this to go quietly on, you are soon under the care of a *committee* as completely as if you were insane. You want no committee: reason, law, religion, the marriage vow; all these have made you head, have given you full power to rule your family, and if you give up your right, you deserve the contempt that assuredly awaits you, and also the ruin that is, in all probability, your doom.

188. Taking it for granted that you will not suffer more than a second or third session of the female committee, let me say a word or two about the conduct of men in deciding between the conflicting opinions of husbands and wives. When a wife has a *point to carry*, and finds herself hard pushed, or when she thinks it necessary to call to her aid all the force she can possibly muster, one of her resources is, the vote on her side of all her husband’s visiting friends. ‘My husband thinks so and so, and I think so and so; now, Mr. Tomkins, don’t you think *I am right*?’ To be sure he does; and so does Mr. Jenkins, and so does Wilkins, and so does Mr. Dickins, and you would swear that they were all her *kins*. Now this is very foolish, to say the least of it. None of these complaisant *kins* would like this in their own case. It is the fashion to say *aye* to all that a woman asserts, or contends for, especially in contradiction to her husband; and a very pernicious fashion it is. It is, in fact, not to pay her a compliment worthy of acceptance, but to treat her as an empty and conceited fool; and no

sensible woman will, except from mere inadvertence, make the appeal. This fashion, however, foolish and contemptible as it is in itself, is attended, very frequently, with serious consequences. Backed by the opinions of her husband’s friends, the wife returns to the charge with redoubled vigour and obstinacy; and if you do not yield, ten to one but a *quarrel* is the result; or, at least, something approaching towards it. A gentleman at whose house I was, about five years ago, was about to take a farm for his eldest son, who was a very fine young man, about eighteen years old. The mother, who was as virtuous and as sensible a woman as I have ever known, wished him to be ‘in the law.’ There were six or eight intimate friends present, and all unhesitatingly joined the lady, thinking it a pity that *Harry*, who had had ‘such a good education,’ should be *buried* in a farm-house. ‘And don’t *you* think so too, Mr. Cobbett,’ said the lady, with great earnestness. ‘Indeed, Ma’am,’ said I, ‘I should think it very great presumption in me to offer any opinion at all, and especially in opposition to the known decision of the father, who is the best judge, and the only rightful judge, in such a case.’ This was a very sensible and well-behaved woman, and I still respect her very highly; but I could perceive that I instantly dropped out of her good graces. Harry, however, I was glad to hear, went ‘to be *buried* in the farm-house.’

189. ‘A house divided against itself,’ or, rather, *in* itself, ‘cannot stand;’ and it *is* divided against itself if there be a *divided authority*. The wife ought to be *heard*, and *patiently* heard; she ought to be reasoned with, and, if possible, convinced; but if,

“‘A house divided against itself,’ or, rather, *in* itself, ‘cannot stand;’ and it *is* divided against itself if there be a *divided authority*.”

after all endeavours in this way, she remain opposed to the husband’s opinion, his will *must* be obeyed; or he, at once, becomes nothing; she is, in fact, the *master*, and he is nothing but an insignificant inmate. As to matters of little comparative moment; as to what shall be for dinner; as to how the house shall be furnished; as to the management of the house and of menial servants; as to these matters, and many others, the wife may have her way without any danger; but when the questions are, what is to be the *calling* to be pursued; what is to be the *place of residence*; what is to be the *style* of living and *scale* of expense; what is to be done with *property*; what the manner and place of educating children; what is to be their *calling* or state of life; who are to be employed or entrusted by the husband; what are the principles that he is to adopt as to public matters; whom he is to have for coadjutors or friends; all these must be left solely to the husband; in all these he must have his will; or there never can be any harmony in the family.

1. Sir Cobbett is, of course, speaking with hyperbole to bring the reader to attention to this grave matter. Such an act (or even thought) is against the natural law and the positive divine law as expressed in the fifth commandment.

2. This is not so in our times! So-called divorce, so-called family courts, trial by media and public opinion, give no such guarantee of the head of the family’s rights.

## LETTERS TO THE EDITOR



### Destruction of the Natural Order

Thank you, editor of the Plough, for your efforts in producing a periodical so effective at recommending the many great stalwarts of Catholicism, to inspire and guide Catholics in today’s time of rebuilding.

I write this letter not to sow discord amongst friends and families, but as a vehicle for conversation to be raised, refuted or proved, distributed and disseminated, in a hope of some potential good.

Recently I visited a large city in my country within the Anglosphere. I navigated my way through the concrete jungle to a store for some domestic items. It wasn’t until part way through the shop that in my travel and perusal, I had not heard my native tongue spoken once. I had passed many people but not seen a citizen of the country. It was quite a realisation. How have things come to be like this?

The ‘liberal agenda’, another skin-suit of International Jewry, promotes open borders. We must ask ourselves, why?

Never attribute to malice that which can be attributed to stupidity. But in this instance, instead of stupidity I believe it to be unrestrained Greed. Credit creation in the hands of private syndicates relies on an ever-increasing Ponzi-scheme of new debtors. This is sold as an economic necessity by the usurious money-creators and the perfidious statesmen they have corrupted. It is dressed up as growth, GDP,

and other economic jargon, to make it palatable to the common man, and less likely to receive the ridicule it deserves. Henry Ford once said, “It is well enough that people of the nation do not understand our banking and monetary system, for if they did, I believe there would be a revolution before tomorrow morning”, and this would not be the eternal revolution prized by the Bolshevik’s of his time.

I believe that this economic driver is the smoke and mirrors to hide the true actions and intents of a nefarious few. It is a vehicle for globalism, or the Jewish secular supnation. In this instance it is malice. A world of people without national identities, with people fractured, with no sense of belonging. The inevitable social turmoil from incompatible cultures makes a people far more susceptible to control through political and economic means. To Divide, Conquer, and Herd. It follows a pattern of the systemic erasure of cultures and histories, these great bastions of defence against these diabolic ideals.

What is the Catholic response to this problem?

Well, I believe the first and only prudent thing to do is to keep one’s head down, don’t rock the boat, and hope that things get better. After all, that’s what the Martyrs did. The Apostle’s left the upper room after the arrival of the Holy Ghost, and for fear of the Jews seeking them, retreated into Galilee to live peaceful lives maintaining the status quo.

I believe history has a slightly different recitation of events, thanks be to God.

A reminder to all good-willed men, that the social good is a real and tangible good—it is the duty of the fathers of families to promote, labour for, and in some cases, die for.

Supernatural grace cannot flow without the natural matter ready to receive it. A starving man thinks not of God. A muslim nation does not produce Catholic Saints.

I think there is more that could and should be said on this issue. There are many avenues to explore, including the basis of nations, cultures and races, and their relationship with each other, as presented in the natural and supernatural order. There are solutions to discuss, weighing their merits and risk. There are consequences to be thought out.

To swim against the tide requires work. I refuse to stand idly by while the inheritance (my country) I am to present to my children is broken, stolen and burned.

I open the floor to other men, and ask for their input on such. If I may be so bold I ask the editor to assist us by presenting to us with the practical and theological grounding of Holy Mother the Church, as you have done so on so many other pertinent subjects.

Let us labour for the social reign of Jesus Christ the King.

— Little Brother John

Thank you for your letter, Little Brother John. In the process of rebuilding society

*we must ensure that we do so with the help of Grace, but also according to the laws of our nature as men. Since the 1960’s, we have been ravaged by all manner of revolutionary theories: obviously as Catholics, we are acutely aware of the revolution in the Church, her liturgy and her doctrine. But other theories, which concern the temporal realm, Catholics have not been so vigilant against. One of them is the theory that nationality or race plays no part in the organisation of the civil society, or that race and nationality are accidental to one’s identity as a man.*

*The Church’s enemies target both the natural and the supernatural as a means of removing God from the earth. If Catholic men of action want to rebuild what was lost for God and our own children, we must humbly examine our own understanding of this question of race and nationality in light of Catholic tradition. We must forge civil societies which are capable both of receiving God’s grace, but also which respect human nature. When both of these needles are threaded, such civil societies form a bulwark against both the natural and supernatural attacks against God by the enemies of Christendom.*

*I reiterate the invitation within your letter, and open up the floor to discussion. God bless you!*

Please visit [www.theplough.ink/contribute](http://www.theplough.ink/contribute) to send a letter in.



# From Babel to Pentecost

## A Thesis on The Catholic View of Nationality

Mario Varraut

*M. M. Varraut is a Frenchman and contemporary of our times. He gives a sound exposition of the Catholicity of rights of nations to remain separate. He outlines that Catholic unity occurs on the supernatural level, and not necessarily on the natural level i.e. the various peoples, histories and traditions of nations around the world should be respected—insofar as they are concordant with the moral law—and this patrimony should not be so easily tossed aside, mixed, blended or forgotten under the conceit of a false unity.*

In chapter 11 of Genesis, human beings decide to build a city and a tower “whose top reaches the heavens.” The text specifies that they had “one single language and the same words,” and that they sought to make a name for themselves and avoid being scattered over the earth.

This project of universal unity, apparently harmonious, is in reality founded on human pride: men want to reach heaven by their own strength, without God. It is a unity constructed from man alone, in a logic of homogenization, control, and self-glorification.

Cosmopolitanism, in its contemporary form, affirms the idea of a single humanity, detached from national, cultural, or religious roots. It values a direct belonging to the human race, often at the expense of concrete identities. It can, like Babel, promote a unity without transcendence, a

form of globalism in which all particularities are dissolved into an undifferentiated whole.

From this perspective, the Tower of Babel appears as a prefiguration of a cosmopolitan world that seeks to establish an absolute unity—linguistic, political, cultural—by erasing foundational differences. The risk is then a totalitarian unity that respects neither the freedom of peoples, nor their diversity, nor their relationship with God.

God does not destroy the people at Babel: He disperses them, He confuses their language. This gesture is not a brutal punishment, but an act of mercy and a limitation of human pride. The plurality of languages, cultures, and nations thus becomes a safeguard against tyrannical uniformity.

Diversity, according to this reading, is willed by God. It forces human beings to humility, to the recognition of otherness, to the search for unity not in fusion but in communion. It is not unity that is bad, but unity without God—artificial unity that denies the richness of differences.

Thus, the Tower of Babel can be read as a biblical critique of modern cosmopolitanism when the latter claims to found an abstract humanity, uprooted, without memory, without places, without limits. It is a warning against ideologies that want to unify the world at the expense of its souls and its histories.

True Christian unity, by contrast, is not

Babel but Pentecost: where languages are multiple but the Spirit is one. Where the universal does not negate the particular but transfigures it.

Joseph de Maistre, against the abstract universalism of the Enlightenment, affirms in his *Considerations on France* that “man does not exist,” but that “Frenchmen, Italians, Russians” exist. This famous formula condenses his critique of cosmopolitanism: to think of man outside any concrete community, any national or religious tradition, is to construct a dangerous abstraction, without flesh, without roots. It is a negation of the necessary mediations between the individual and the divine.

Now, this is exactly what Babel proposes: a humanity unified by itself, in a project of collective omnipotence. One could say, with Maistre, that Babel represents the revolutionary dream of autonomous man, who claims to found himself without God, without tradition, without limits—a form of collective rationalism applied to the order of the world. The tower that one wants to raise to heaven is a powerful image of this modern hybris, which Maistre never ceased to denounce.

For him, human history cannot be understood without divine providence, without sacred hierarchy, without the mediation of deeply rooted institutions—particularly the monarchy and the Church. The project of Babel, like that of modern Revolutions, is an attempt to destroy these mediations in favor of a purely human universalism, and therefore inevitably violent.

But Scripture does not end with Babel. It gives, in the Acts of the Apostles, a luminous counterpoint: Pentecost. There too, men of all languages are gathered. But instead of unifying by force, they receive the same Spirit that allows them to understand one another in their differences. It is not the single language of Babel, but mutual understanding through the diversity of languages. It is not a human project, but a divine gift.

Here Maistre’s thought fully joins the message of Pentecost: there can be no true unity except in transcendence, in the reception of a higher principle that respects differences instead of erasing them. Christian unity is not fusion but communion. It does not deny nations; it orders them to God. And for Maistre, each nation has its own mission in the history of Providence—France in particular, according to him, being called to a spiritual mission.

Thus, while Babel embodies a constructivist cosmopolitanism that seeks unity from below, through politics and technique, Pentecost embodies a Christian universality that comes from above, from the Spirit, and that elevates nations without destroying them.

Maistre invites us to reject the idea of a humanity without nations, just as he rejects the idea of power without God. Babel, in his reading, could be the prefiguration of all modern projects of a “new man” detached from his heritage, his language, his land, his religion. Pentecost, on the contrary, symbolizes a vertical unity, rooted in grace, respectful of differences, ordered to charity.

This is why one can affirm, with Maistre, that true universalism is not cosmopolitan but Catholic—that is, universal from above, not uniform from below.

For René Girard, the foundation of hu-

“Christian unity is not fusion but communion. It does not deny nations; it orders them to God. And for Maistre, each nation has its own mission in the history of Providence—France in particular, according to him, being called to a spiritual mission.”

man societies rests on the regulation of mimetic desire: men desire what others desire, which inevitably leads to generalized conflict unless a society channels this violence through mechanisms of exclusion or ritual differentiation (the scapegoat, taboos, hierarchical structures...).

Now, in the story of Babel, everything is homogeneous: one single language, one single people, one single project. It is precisely this absence of differentiation that Girard identifies as the threshold of absolute mimetic danger. When all desire the same thing (here: “to make a name,” to reach heaven, to build a unique work), rivalry intensifies. Unity becomes unstable, explosive. What seems to be a project of harmony is in reality fertile ground for mimetic violence.

Thus, the Tower of Babel can be read as an anticipatory critique of unifying cosmopolitanism, where the erasure of differences generates mass mimicry. Modern cosmopolitanism, in claiming to unify humanity under a global culture, a world language, a common market, suppresses the cultural mediations that once defused conflict. It creates a world without exteriority, where desire becomes circular, turned in on itself, destined for saturation.

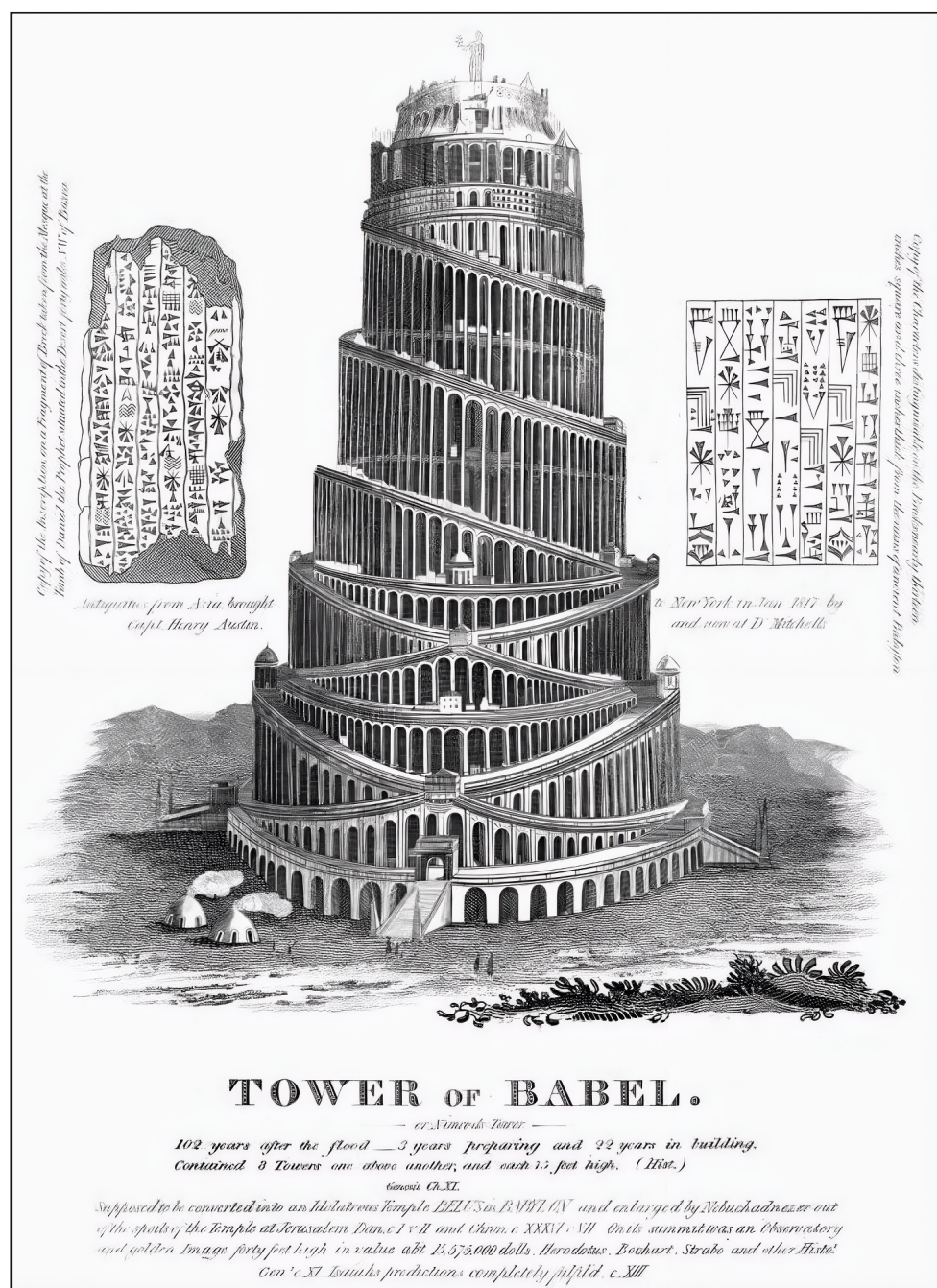
God’s response—the dispersion, the plurality of languages—is not a curse but a prophylactic act, a reintroduction of structuring difference. For Girard, culture arises precisely from differentiation: myths, rites, prohibitions. The plurality of languages, traditions, and nations is what prevents the outbreak of mimetic violence.

By confusing the single language, God prevents the unleashing of a collective desire that would inevitably have led to a sacrificial crisis. The world becomes polyphonic, each person recovering a necessary distance, its own rhythm, its own otherness. It is a way of saving humanity from itself by establishing a balance of differences.

But the divine project is not eternal separation. It is true communion, realized not from below (through technique, power, collective imitation) but through the gift of the Spirit. Pentecost, for Girard, is an anti-Babel: each person hears the Apostles in his own language, which means that Christian unity does not come through uniformization but through the recognition and inclusion of difference.

At Pentecost, mimetic desire is purified: it is no longer founded on rivalry but oriented toward a model that does not rival—the Christ. It is a pacified desire, which unites without confusing, which gathers without homogenizing.

In a Girardian reading, cosmopolitanism is a modern Babel: a dream of unity founded on the erasure of mediations, limits, differences. This dream leads to crisis, to the saturation of desire, to violence. Conversely, the Christian vision of univer-



The Tower of Babel, the ultimate symbol of pride: to reach God by the power of the union of man.

Continued on Page 11





# From Babel to Pentecost Cont.

Continued from Page 10

sality is that of Pentecost: it recognizes plurality, welcomes the other in his language and culture, but under a common breath that comes from above.

What Girard helps us understand is that human unity cannot be founded on a hidden sacrificial mechanism (as in Babel, where unity presupposes the suppression of differences), but on the revelation of the victim mechanism by Christ and the exit from the logic of rivalry.

Modern cosmopolitanism, by erasing borders, roots, and particularities, paradoxically reintroduces the conflict it claims

to abolish, because it ignores mimetic dynamics and the need for real otherness. The Bible, from Babel to Pentecost, shows us instead the path of a unity founded not on fusion but on reconciliation—and this reconciliation is possible only through a desire oriented toward transcendence.

Benedict XVI has always distinguished between Christian universality, founded on truth, love, and freedom, and modern ideological universalism, which tends to impose a single vision of the world, often detached from all transcendence.

In the project of Babel, he sees a unity built by human will alone, a Promethean temptation to build a unified world with-

out God. This is what he sometimes calls reason closed in on itself, which claims to organize humanity through technique, politics, or economics without reference to the divine.

But for him, such a project inevitably leads to inhumanity, because it forgets what man truly is: a being made for truth, for dialogue with God, for freedom ordered to the good. Modern cosmopolitanism, when it becomes absolutist, falls into this logic: in claiming to unite humanity from below (market, language, rights without duties, communication without communion), it ends up denying the deep identities of peoples, their memory, their religious dimension.

In several of his interventions (notably his famous Regensburg lecture in 2006), Benedict XVI warns against a rationalism separated from faith, which produces closed systems—political, economic, or technological—incapable of responding to the deepest aspirations of man.

Babel, in this reading, is an archetype of modern totalitarianism: a world where one speaks a single language, where diversity is seen as an obstacle to efficiency, where unity is imposed from above. There is here a strong resonance with the communist ideology of the 20th century, but also with certain forms of contemporary globalism: the idea that humanity must be governed according to exclusively technical, universal, “neutral” criteria—that is, in reality, dehumanized.

Against Babel, Benedict XVI invites us to contemplate Pentecost. What he sees there is the restoration of unity in truth and love, but without destroying differences. The Apostles speak in the Spirit, and each person hears them in his own language.

This means that the Christian faith respects the cultural identity of peoples while calling them to a higher communion.

This is the strength of Catholic universality according to Benedict XVI: it does not erase identities; it purifies them, elevates them, opens them. He opposes visions that confuse unity with uniformity. The Church, according to him, is the antidote to Babel because it is the place of a transcendent unity, born of the love of God and not of technique or ideology.

Finally, Benedict XVI often insists on a fundamental point: only truth makes genuine unity possible. And truth, in his thought, is not an authoritarian concept but something that is received. It presupposes listening, humility, openness to mystery. Modern cosmopolitanism, which often claims to be post-truth, post-religious, post-traditional, condemns itself to failure: it builds Babels that will sooner or later collapse.

The true unity of humanity can be found only in Christ, who is truth made flesh, the Word that gives meaning to all languages. This is why the mission of the Church is profoundly political—not in the sense of purely earthly power, but because it offers humanity a living unity, rooted, respectful, founded on the person of Christ the King and not on an ideological system.

Benedict XVI teaches us that the modern world risks rebuilding Babel: a global society without soul, without transcendence, without limits. But he reminds us that the true path is not that of fusion but of communion. History is not meant to end at Babel but at Rome—not Rome merely as empire, but as Church, that is, as the place of incarnate universality, in the plurality of peoples gathered by faith.

Whereas Babel was a human attempt to create unity from above by crushing differences (single language, centralized power),

“Whereas Babel was a human attempt to create unity from above by crushing differences (single language, centralized power), Pentecost is the work of God who sends down the Spirit so that each people may hear the Word ‘in his own language.’”

Pentecost is the work of God who sends down the Spirit so that each people may hear the Word “in his own language.”

It is not uniformity that creates unity, but the reception of the same Spirit in multiple languages, cultures, and peoples. Unity is not fusion but communion.

Pentecost marks the public birth of the Church, not as a human institution but as a living Body animated by the Spirit.

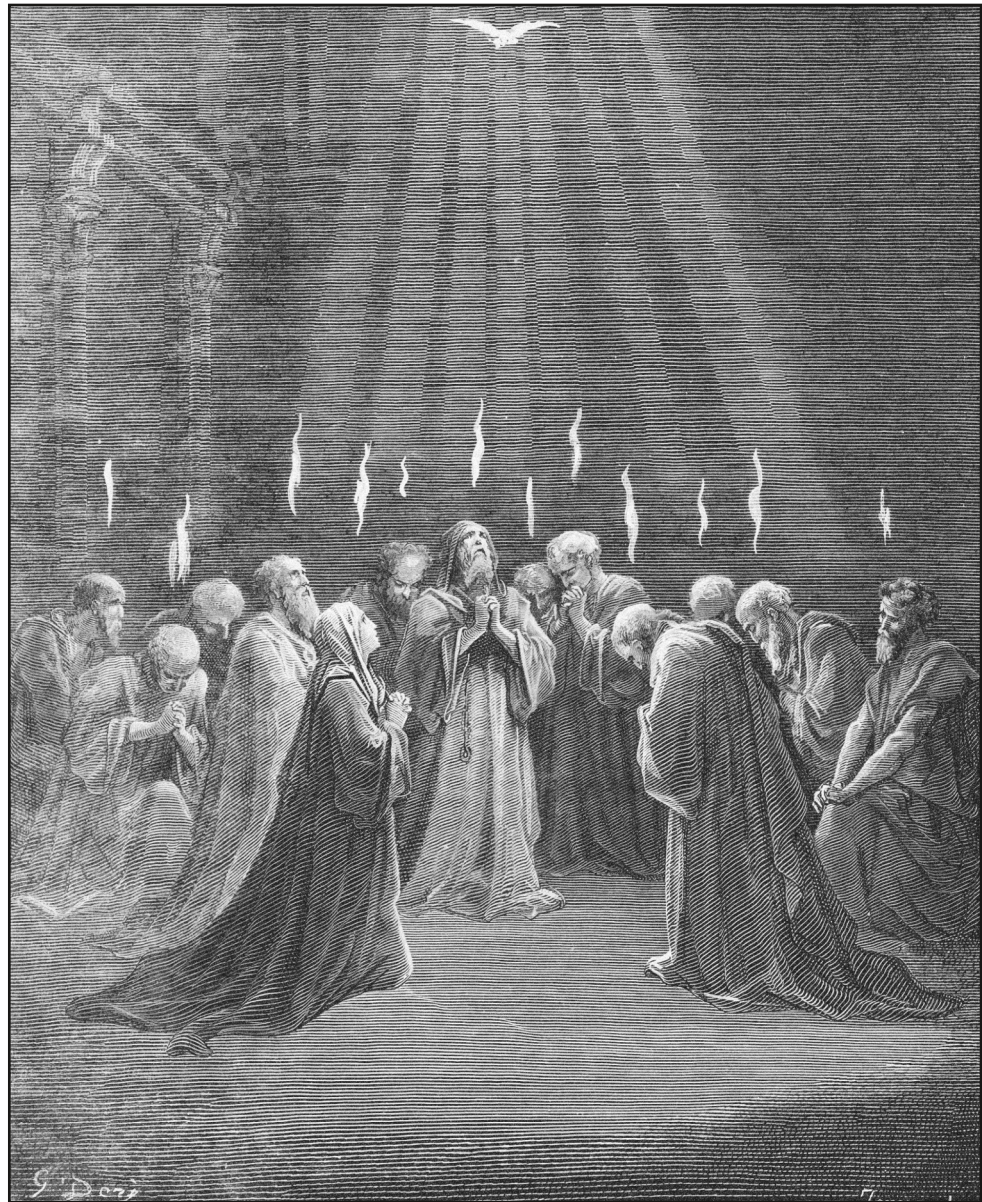
It is the Church that speaks all languages, that is Catholic in the proper sense (*katholikos*, in ancient Greek): universal, yet rooted in each people. This moment reveals that the Christian faith is destined for all nations, not merely as conquest but as gift.

The gift of the Spirit completes the mission of Christ: after the Incarnation (God among us) and the Resurrection (God victorious over death), comes Pentecost: God within us.

It is the passage from a religion centered on the Law to a faith vivified by Grace. The Spirit does not replace the Word; He makes it alive in hearts.

Pentecost opposes all technocratic, political, or cosmopolitan utopias that want to unite humanity without God, by erasing differences.

It reminds us that only transcendence allows true peace: communion in freedom and truth. This is what Benedict XVI wrote: “Without God, peace is illusory, and unity becomes oppression.”



Pentecost, the descent of the Holy Ghost: Gustave Doré 1832–1883.

## NOTE FROM THE EDITOR

Welcome, dear Reader, to the ninth issue of *The Plough*.

In the season after Pentecost, the Church presents in her liturgy a marvellous sequence of feasts: Pentecost, Trinity Sunday, Corpus Christi, Feast of the Sacred Heart etc. No doubt the Church times this sequence with the peak of summer—for those of us in the Southern Hemisphere, or rather, speaking just for myself: I will be thinking of you enviously!

The season after Pentecost is aplenty with the motif of the Holy Ghost working in our souls for our sanctification. It is not a coincidence, then, that this season is the longest in the liturgical calendar! “And while they were beholding him going up to heaven, behold two men stood by them in white garments. Who also said: Ye men of Galilee, why stand you looking up to heaven?” It is as if the angel is saying: Get to work!

Let us get to work! However, let us be reminded that ‘getting to work’ is not a call to a chaotic spasm of activity, but rather a long graft of intentional and reasoned labour. Let us hear the words of the sacred writer: “But that

on the good ground, are they who in a good and perfect heart, hearing the word, keep it, and bring forth fruit in patience.”

Bring forth fruit in *patience*. We must not be perturbed from our good course because the resulting fruit comes forth in *patience*.

Each good action is like a swing of the axe against the tree. Each swing seems to do nothing. But each swing is necessary, and each swing is one less swing needed to bring the tree down.

For Catholic men of action, each sacrifice, each conversation, every prayer under our breath, every trip to Mass, every witness to the truth, is counted and credited. Let us not be disheartened by the size of the tree that we are bringing down, but rather let us keep our focus on our ‘swing’, let us persevere in our good course, and let us, by the help of the Third Person of the Blessed Trinity, bring forth fruit in patience.

Thank you for your loyal patronage, dear Reader, and may God bless you,  
Editor of *The Plough*.

Mario Varraut is the Editor of Editions Saint Barthélemy, a French language publisher focusing on French history and politics. They can be found at [editionssaintbarthelemy.fr](http://editionssaintbarthelemy.fr)

PUZZLE SOLUTIONS

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# Francisco Franco and His Social Programme

## An Intimate Interview

Fr Joseph Thorning

*This short interview conducted with the Spanish Head of State Francisco Franco provides some fantastic insight on how the Catholic social principles governed the Caudillo's thinking on his economic policy. The final question and response is particularly interesting: Franco, for all the good he did for Spain, and for all his personal devotion and piety, fails spectacularly in answering this question—perhaps a strong Catholic response could've secured a greater future for the Spanish nation after his death. From his book Builders of the Social Order, published in 1941.*

**Q.** What attention has Your Excellency given to the principles of justice for the workingman enunciated by Leo XIII in the *Rerum Novarum* and by Pius XI in the *Quadragesimo Anno*?

**A.** As head of the Spanish nation, which looks to the Holy See for authoritative guidance in the supreme question of ethical and moral practice, I have naturally studied with profound attention the pronouncements of our religious leaders upon the proposed solutions to the evil of social injustice in the world. Obviously, the doctrines of the papal encyclicals furnish a sound program of social and economic reconstruction. The application of these principles, however, must be considered in relation to the genius and traditions of the Spanish people. For that reason a number of my collaborators are making a detailed study of the methods of application that would be suitable for Spain.

Of this you may be certain: we shall provide a living wage for every agricultural worker. Furthermore, the State will devise means to reward proportionately those who are charged with family responsibilities. I believe firmly in the principle of the family wage. One of our principal concerns in the midst of war has been the thorough preservation of family life. To the best of our ability we have avoided the necessity of conscripting the head of the house. In this respect our record contrasts favorably with that of our enemies who conscripted soldiers without regard to their social obligations.

The fact that the Holy See has been prompt to recognize the Nationalist Government and to receive the credentials of our diplomatic representative in Rome is a proof that the Vatican has entire confidence in our conscientious desire to carry out the recommendations of the *Rerum Novarum* and the *Quadragesimo Anno*. The factory workers in the great industrial center of Bilbao can give you first-hand testimony as to the efficacy of our program of economic reconstruction.

**Q.** Is Your Excellency prepared to state that Spain will recognize the right of the workers to a share in the profits of industry?

**A.** Both employers and employees will receive a share of the fruits of industrial production. This rule will apply to both native-born and foreign capitalists. If the latter refuse to conform to our ideal of justice, they will not be welcome in Spain.

**Q.** Does Your Excellency accept the principle that workers should be afforded a reasonable measure of security against the hazards of sickness, unemployment and old age?

**A.** Every enlightened nation gives its hearty support to this principle. Spain will be in the forefront of this movement. Anyone who has followed our history for the past twelve months knows that our first care has been for those members of the civil population who were wrenched from their homes and employment due to the conditions of anarchy and chaos which surrounded the victims of Red rule. Ask this question of the women and children who were rescued from starvation and suffering at Bilbao and Santander. They have experienced at first-hand the comforts of our policy of social security. On every hand the Spanish Army is hailed as the guarantee of peace and order, the indispensable pillars of social security.

**Q.** Is Your Excellency committed to the ideal of the corporative State?

**A.** This is a general term and may be easily misunderstood. Corporatism in Spain will grant to every citizen the right to participate in the social and economic life of the country on the basis of his labors. In other words, the prime requisite of civic responsibility will be function. In this way it will be possible to avoid the dangers which arise from corrupt politics or outmoded geographical divisions. I believe that this will be an effective

antidote for separatism and particularism, two evils which have long plagued Spanish political life. Our Corporatism, however, will be indigenous, domestic, Spanish. It will be suited to the individualism of the Spanish personality. It will not be slavishly modeled upon foreign patterns. It should be noted, for example, that the system of corporations set up by Dr. Oliviera Salazar in Portugal is Iberian, not continental. We in Spain will fashion our own type of corporation in the arts, industry, agriculture and professions.

**Q.** Does Your Excellency believe that there would be any danger of excessive State regimentation in this corporative system?

**A.** The present administration of Spain shows that this danger may be kept far in the background. We have not interfered with any of the legitimate demands of private enterprise. Our sole purpose has been to prevent profiteering, the cancerous growth which springs from war and enriches a few at the expense of the great bulk of the population.

Every sincere foreign observer has commented upon the absence of profiteering in Nationalist Spain. Prices are altogether normal and in no case excessive. Indeed, there are some commodities which can be purchased at a price lower than that which was current at the outbreak of the war of liberation. This is not regimentation. It is a proper protection of the consuming public. To be sure profits of brokers, speculators and middlemen have been curtailed, but business has not suffered. Supplies of foodstuffs are plentiful and there is no hoarding, a phenomenon which usually accompanies armed conflict. The State has been vigilant in punishing any attempted case of gouging and as a result temptations to this form of exploitation are few.

The same principle applies to rents. Property-holders are entitled to a fair return of their investment, but they have not been permitted to engage in a wholesale kiting of rents. Revenues from property may be moderate but they have the advantage of steadiness and security. Naturally, we cannot speak of a large-scale housing program until all Spain has been liberated.

**Q.** What do you consider to be the principal needs of the farm population of Spain?

“Obviously, the doctrines of the papal encyclicals furnish a sound program of social and economic reconstruction. The application of these principles, however, must be considered in relation to the genius and traditions of the Spanish people.”

**A.** This question deserves thorough study. Lack of sufficient rainfall on the plateau regions of the peninsula makes the question of irrigation of pivotal importance. But irrigation postulates a huge volume of water in year-round rivers. This condition does not exist throughout Spain. What water is available must be carefully husbanded and utilized. Reforestation will be an undoubted boon. Diversification of crops, as in so many other countries, will also vastly improve the diet of the agricultural workers. Spain has the soil to produce rich crops of fruits and vegetables. A larger proportion of this produce should be consumed on the farm. Dairy production can likewise be stepped up to an enormous extent. We have grazing land in plenty and an excellent grade of stock animals. There is no reason why the exercise of creative imagination should not work miracles for the large number of Spaniards who till the soil. Modern machinery and scientific farm knowledge will complete the transformation.

**Q.** What will be the trade policy of Spain under Your Excellency's régime?

**A.** Spain will show a vigorous leadership in the restoration of world trade. Up to the present, in spite of the severe strain of daily war, Spain has financed herself from the sale of products abroad. As a result there has been a just balance between imports and exports. Spanish iron, wool, cork and olive oil are highly prized articles of export. On the other hand, Spain is an admirable market for textiles, electrical apparatus, farm machinery and automobiles. Buying and selling is of the essence of trade. Spain is prepared to continue both on a sound basis of cash and credit.

We have no desire to be isolated from world economy. And we believe the reciprocal trade treaties of the United States of America, especially as they have been operative with South American countries, furnish interesting examples of how national benefits may be articulated with the trade exigencies of good neighbors. Spain too has excellent cultural and economic relations with the Republics of South America.

**Q.** What guarantees of religion does Your Excellency provide in Spain?

**A.** Spain guarantees complete religious liberty, as opposed to mere religious toleration, to all who believe in God. There will be no penalties in the realm of conscience. In fact, a high realization of religious and moral values is the most helpful motivation for a program of social justice. Advances in material civilization will be taken step by step with progress in the cultivation of spiritual ideals. These two bear the relationship of soul and body. The hearts and minds of Spaniards will guide their hands in the task that lies before them.



Francisco Franco, Head of the Spanish State, meeting with a unidentified Cardinal. Franco lamented the liberalisation of Roman Churchmen, who he said were aiding in the destruction of Spain. Making an address on Spanish television Franco, said in reference to the communist clergy: "The state will move to oppose whatever interferences with its sovereignty it may encounter, if these have the aim of perturbing the healthy harmony among Spaniards."